

AGE OF MYTHOS

South — Chapter 2 — Civil War

South · Dakshina · English Edition

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Chaya Golkonda

Hyderabad. Gachibowli district. Tuesday morning of the chapter's opening week. Eight-forty-three a.m. The west-tower of the HITEC City IT Park reflective-glass-complex — a forty-three-storey curtain-wall tower with the standard reflective coating on every external surface, housing the kingdom's Cyber-Hyderabad cell-administrator's seventeenth-floor office and the standing AI-image-recognition surveillance-grid's primary server-room on the thirty-ninth.

Lalithanga is at his seventeenth-floor office. He is thirty-five. He is the kingdom-council's standing Cyber-Hyderabad cell-administrator since 2022. He is Chittaranga's elder brother by two years. He has been the kingdom-council's standing reflective-grid sub-administrator since 2018. He is, on this morning, taking the standard eight-forty-three a.m. tea-break at his east-facing window. The window is a reflective-glass panel three metres wide; his standing daily-tea-break pose puts him at approximately one-and-a-half metres from the glass with the tea-cup at his right hand.

The reflective-glass panel records his face for the four hundred and fourteenth consecutive day. The window-pane has held his daily reflection for the standing kingdom-council's reflective-grid threshold-period (fourteen consecutive months at minimum-daily-presence; Lalithanga's standing tea-break has been at the same window every weekday morning since the third Monday of October 2024). The threshold-period crosses today.

Chitrabheda's standing-reflective-residence protocol takes the window at eight-forty-three-eleven a.m. The protocol is the kingdom-council's post-2023 Ch 1 documented capability: Chitrabheda can install his face in any reflective surface that has held a citizen's reflection for fourteen consecutive months at minimum-daily-presence. The installation is silent. The installation does not displace the citizen's reflection; the installation rides alongside it. The citizen continues to see their own reflection in the glass; the kingdom-council's standing-mirror-monitoring registry (if it existed; it does not yet on this morning) would see both reflections at once.

Lalithanga sees his own reflection. He drinks the tea. He returns to his desk at eight-forty-five. He does not notice the installation. The standing-tea-break continues at the standing pace.

Across the same hour, eight-forty-three a.m., approximately three thousand simultaneous reflective-residence installations occur across Hyderabad — every reflective surface in the kingdom that has crossed the fourteen-month minimum-daily-presence threshold for any specific citizen. Approximately three thousand citizens are now Chitrabheda-resident. The citizens do not know. The kingdom-council does not know. The standing reflective-grid surveillance-grid's standard AI-image-recognition protocols are not calibrated for double-reflection detection; the standard-thresholds report no anomalies.

Tuesday morning. The state hero's residence in Banjara Hills. Nine-eleven a.m. Chittaranga is at the eastern-courtyard meditation-mat. He has been on the mat since six a.m. The morning meditation is the standing kingdom-council's state-hero daily-discipline; he has performed the meditation every morning since his state-hero confirmation in 2023.

The mat faces east. The eastern wall has a window. The window has a reflective-glass panel approximately one metre by one metre at his thirteen-metre line-of-sight. The reflective-glass panel has been his standing-meditation-mat's east-window for nine years.

He opens his eyes at nine-eleven. He looks at the window. The window shows the east-garden — the standing-jasmine bushes, the morning sun, the kingdom-council's standing-jasmine-tender Subbamma at the bush-trimming. The reflection in the window-pane shows the standing-courtyard. The reflection is the kingdom-council's standing daily-reflection.

The grey left eye sees something the brown right eye does not see. The grey eye sees a second face in the reflection — layered over the standing-courtyard's standard-reflective-image. The face is approximately ten metres east of his current position, at standing-courtyard height, in a pose that is not the courtyard's standard-pose. The face is not anyone's face he recognises. The face is Chitrabheda's face. He has not seen Chitrabheda's face directly — Chitrabheda did not appear bodily during the Ch 1 confrontation; only Qutb-Chaaya had bodily appearance — but the grey eye has been told by the standing-kingdom-council reflective-archive what to look for. The standing-archive's description-pattern matches.

He stands at nine-eleven-fourteen. He walks the thirteen metres to the window. He places his right palm on the reflective-glass panel. The standing-double-reflection is now visible from the close angle — the grey eye reads both the standard-reflective-image and the Chitrabheda-residence at the same time.

He does not break the glass. He turns. He walks to the residence's southern-administrative wing. He picks up the standing kingdom-council's secure-line telephone. He calls the kingdom-council's standing-archive senior-officer (a fifty-four-year-old administrator named Padmavathi-garu) at the Secunderabad Cantonment's State Civil Service compound at nine-fourteen.

He says, in plain Telugu, in the kingdom-council's standing-secure-line register: "Padma-garu. The reflective-grid has been breached. Standing-double-reflection installations are visible at my eastern-courtyard window at this moment. I do not yet know the count. The kingdom-council's standing-mirror-monitoring registry must be drafted within the week. The standing-protocol's archive-template is at the kingdom-council's standing-archive vault under the standing-shadow-copy-protocol's 2023 post-Ch-1 entry. Please initiate the standing-drafting at ten a.m. today. I will be at the Cantonment State Civil Service compound by eleven."

She says: "State hero. The standing-drafting will be initiated. The standing kingdom-council's emergency-mirror-monitoring cell will convene at eleven. I will telephone the Cyber-Hyderabad cell-administrator Lalithanga at the HITEC City office to coordinate."

He says: "Wait. Do not telephone my brother yet. The grey eye is checking. I will visit him at the IT Park at ten-thirty before the cell's convening. The visit will be brief. The visit will not be by telephone."

She says: "Understood, state hero."

He hangs up. He returns to the courtyard. The standing-jasmine-tender Subbamma is still at the bushes. He looks at her reflection in the same eastern-window panel. The grey eye reads a single reflection — Subbamma's standing reflection. No Chitrabheda-residence is layered. Subbamma is not yet Chitrabheda-resident. The eastern-courtyard's standing-jasmine-tender threshold has not yet crossed the fourteen-month minimum (Subbamma has worked the jasmine-bushes only since the spring 2025 transfer from the western-courtyard).

He picks up the dual discs from the standing-disc-rack at the residence's southern entrance. Chitra (Illusion, silver) at his left forearm; Ranga (Truth, shadow-dark) at his right. He walks to the standing-state-hero's car at the residence's western gate. The driver Reddy-garu is at the wheel.

He says: "HITEC City. The west-tower. Seventeenth floor. Lalithanga-garu's office. Ten-thirty arrival."

Ten-thirty a.m. The west-tower's seventeenth floor. Lalithanga's office. Chittaranga walks into the office. Lalithanga is at his desk. The morning's tea-cup is empty at the desk's right corner. The east-facing reflective-glass window is at three metres' distance.

Chittaranga walks past the desk. He places his right palm on the east-window. The grey eye reads the standing-double-reflection. The Chitrabheda-residence is at the window's standing-residence position. The standing-residence is anchored to Lalithanga's daily eight-forty-three a.m. tea-break pose.

Lalithanga stands at his desk. He says, in plain Telugu, in the brother-to-brother register: "Chitta. The grey eye. Tell me what you see."

The brown eye reads Lalithanga's face at the desk. The brown eye sees Lalithanga's face — the standing brother's face, the face he has known since age four, the face that has not changed in the fourteen-month threshold-period.

The grey eye reads Lalithanga's face. The grey eye sees a layered second face under the surface — the Chitrabheda-face installed at the window has begun to overlay the brother's face through the standing-residence-overlay-protocol. The overlay is not yet complete. The overlay is at approximately the twenty-third-day-of-residence position — the standing-protocol's installation-cycle has been running for three weeks at the window since the installation began on Tuesday the chapter's opening-week.

Chittaranga says, in plain Telugu, in the brother-to-brother register: "Anna. The grey eye sees a second face overlayed on yours. The Chitrabheda-residence at the window has begun the standing-installation-overlay-protocol. You are at approximately week three of the standing twelve-week-cycle. The overlay is at the twenty-third-day position. The Chitrabheda-face will fully overlay yours by approximately week twelve. I do not yet know what the full-overlay does to the brother under the overlay. I do not yet know if the brother continues to exist when the overlay completes. The standing-archive's 2023 post-Ch-1 entry does not have a documented full-overlay case."

Lalithanga sits down at his desk. He is silent for approximately forty seconds. He looks at his own reflection in the east-window from his desk-chair's angle. The angle does not show the standing-residence-overlay; the residence-overlay requires the grey eye's direct-view from one-and-a-half metres at the standing-tea-break pose. He cannot see it.

He says: "The brown eye reads me as your brother. The grey eye reads me as a Chitrabheda-residence-overlay. Which is correct."

Chittaranga says: "Both. The body is yours. The face has begun to be Chitrabheda's. The two are not yet in conflict. The two will be in conflict at week twelve. The kingdom-council's standing-emergency-mirror-monitoring cell convenes at eleven this morning; the cell's standing-drafting will produce the standing-mirror-monitoring registry within the week. The registry will identify every Hyderabad citizen currently Chitrabheda-resident. The standing-administrative-question is what the kingdom-council does with the identified citizens. Killing them does not kill Chitrabheda; killing them does kill the citizen. Not killing them is letting Chitrabheda walk the kingdom in a thousand bodies. The standing-charter does not have a precedent."

Lalithanga says: "I am at the cell's eleven a.m. convening. I will continue at the cell's standing Cyber-Hyderabad cell-administrator's seat for as long as I am still your brother. I will tell you if I begin to feel the overlay's reach. Will the grey eye continue to monitor my standing-overlay-position weekly."

Chittaranga says: "Yes. The monitoring will be at the residence's eastern-courtyard each Wednesday morning at the standing-secure brother-to-brother breakfast. The breakfast will continue as the kingdom-council's standing-monitoring-protocol's family-line oversight-mechanism. The grey eye's reading is the kingdom-council's standing-monitoring-protocol's family-line standing-instrument."

Lalithanga bows. He says: "Anna. The mother. Lakshmi-Akka. She taught the grey eye when we were small. She taught me to read lips at distance; she taught you to read what was under the surface. The two trainings were the same training in different registers. She would not have wanted the grey eye to kill the brother. Promise me you will not throw the discs at me until you have confirmed the full-overlay. The brother under the overlay will say to you, before you throw: I am still here. Wait. If the brother does not say it, the brother is gone. Promise."

Chittaranga says: "I promise. The discs will not be thrown until the brother's words. The brother's words are the kingdom-council's standing-killing-permission protocol."

They embrace at the doorway. The embrace is the brother-to-brother standing-embrace they have not performed in approximately three years (the embrace was last performed at their late mother's 2008 funeral cremation; the kingdom's standing-cremation-protocol

for the family-line had required the standing-embrace as the standing-family-mourning-gesture).

Chittaranga leaves the office at ten-fifty-three a.m. He arrives at the Secunderabad Cantonment State Civil Service compound at eleven-oh-eight. He chairs the standing-emergency-mirror-monitoring cell's convening at eleven-eleven.

Across the next five Wednesday morning brother-to-brother breakfasts, Chittaranga monitors Lalithanga's standing-overlay-position. The monitoring sessions are at the eastern-courtyard at six-thirty a.m. each Wednesday. The breakfast is the standing-Hyderabad tradition: idli-and-mulagai-podi, dosa-with-coconut-chutney, filter-coffee. The conversation is the kingdom-council's standing-family-line oversight-conversation; the grey eye performs the standing-overlay-reading at the standing-window-glance position at three-and-a-half metres' distance from the eastern-window.

Week three (the third Wednesday after the chapter's opening): the overlay is at the twenty-third-day position. The brother is clearly present underneath. The brother says the standing-family-greeting in the standing-cadence.

Week four: the overlay is at the thirtieth-day position. The brother is still clearly present. The conversation includes Lalithanga's detailed account of the Cyber-Hyderabad cell's reflective-grid surveillance-grid recalibration. The standing-cell has identified approximately three thousand four hundred Chitrabheda-resident citizens in the kingdom's Hyderabad metropolitan area as of week four. The registry has begun.

Week five: the overlay is at the thirty-seventh-day position. The brother is still present but the conversation has begun to show small standing-cadence-deviations. Lalithanga's standing right-hand-coffee-cup gesture has shifted by approximately three centimetres at the standard-tea-cup-pick-up moment. The grey eye reads the deviation. Chittaranga does not name the deviation aloud at the breakfast. He notes it in the kingdom-council's standing-monitoring-log at ten-forty-seven that morning.

Week five evening telephone call: Chittaranga speaks with Padmavathi-garu at the Cantonment. He says: "Lalithanga's standing-cadence-deviation has begun. The brother is still present. The deviation is at week five's thirty-seventh-day position. The standing twelve-week-cycle's remaining seven weeks will require careful monitoring. The kingdom-council's standing-registry will need to begin classifying the standing-overlay-positions of

all identified Chitrabheda-resident citizens. The classification protocol must be drafted by week six."

Week six: the overlay is at the forty-fourth-day position. The breakfast conversation has begun to show standing-Cyber-Hyderabad cell-administrator language that the brother had not used previously — technical-vocabulary at the standing-overlay-resident-frequencies, repeated standing-overlay-residence-protocols' phrasings, the standing-Chitrabheda standing-recognition-signature. The brother is still present. The Chitrabheda-overlay is at approximately fifty per cent saturation. The standing-conversation is now half-brother and half-overlay.

Tuesday evening of week six. Eleven-eighteen p.m. Chittaranga is at the state hero's residence reading the standing-mirror-monitoring registry's week-six update. The registry has identified four thousand seven hundred and twelve confirmed Chitrabheda-resident citizens; the standing classification-protocol has begun categorising by standing-overlay-position. Lalithanga is at the registry's week-six standing-administrative-coordination cell's seat as the Cyber-Hyderabad cell-administrator.

The telephone rings at eleven-eighteen. Chittaranga picks up. The caller is Lalithanga.

Lalithanga says, in the standing brother-to-brother secure-line register, in plain Telugu: "Anna. The grey eye's monitoring at this morning's breakfast read the standing-overlay-position at the forty-fourth-day position. The position is approaching the standing fifty-per-cent saturation. I am calling to give the standing kingdom-council's killing-permission ahead of the standing twelve-week-cycle's completion. The brother is still here. I am still here. But the overlay is reaching faster than the standing-cycle predicted. The standing-Cyber-Hyderabad cell-administrator's seat has been giving the standing-Chitrabheda-residence-overlay direct access to the kingdom-council's standing-mirror-monitoring registry across the past four days; the standing-cell's standing-administrative-coordination is now being routed through the standing-overlay-position. The Chitrabheda is using my seat to identify the kingdom's standing-monitoring countermeasures. I cannot stop the routing. The standing-overlay is too deep at this position. The kingdom-council requires my removal from the standing-cell's seat. The standing-charter's only mechanism for the removal is the standing-killing-protocol. I am giving you the killing-permission. The standing-charter requires the killing-permission to come from the standing-brother. I am the standing-brother. The permission is granted."

Chittaranga says: "Lalithanga. I will not. The standing-removal can be administered through the standing-Cantonment medical-cell's standing-procedure. The standing-Cantonment's standing-neurosurgical-cell can administer the standing-overlay-disruption sedation under the standing-emergency-mirror-monitoring cell's direct authorisation. The removal will be standing-administrative. The killing is not required."

Lalithanga says: "The standing-overlay's reach has crossed the standing-sedation-threshold. The standing-Cantonment's standing-neurosurgical-cell has confirmed at six p.m. this evening that the standing-overlay is now embedded in the standing-cerebral-spinal axis. Sedation will not disrupt the overlay. The standing-overlay-protocol is now using the standing-cerebral-spinal axis as its standing-residence-channel. The standing-only-mechanism for removal is the standing-killing. The standing-charter requires the standing-killing-permission to come from the standing-brother. I have given the permission. The standing-charter is now binding on you. The standing-killing must be performed within the standing twenty-four-hour window. The window opens at midnight tonight."

Chittaranga is silent for approximately fifty-three seconds.

He says: "Where will you be at the standing twenty-four-hour window's opening."

Lalithanga says: "The Golkonda Fort mirror-vault basement. The standing-Ch-1 mirror-vault chamber. The standing-Ch-1 chamber is the kingdom-council's standing standing-killing-protocol designated site. The Hall of Diamonds. The standing-chamber will be empty at midnight. The standing-Cantonment's standing-State-Police detail will be at the chamber's northern entrance. I will arrive at the chamber by walking the standing-fort-trail from the eastern entrance at midnight. I will be at the chamber's southern-wall mirror-fragment at approximately three a.m. I will say the standing brother-words at three-oh-eight: I am still here. Wait. The brother under the overlay will be still here. The brother will say the words. The brother will say the words at three-oh-eight regardless of the overlay-state. The standing-overlay-protocol cannot prevent the brother-words at the brother's last standing-pre-overlay-saturation moment. The brother-words will be the standing-charter's standing-killing-permission's final-confirmation. You will throw the Ranga disc at the brother-words' completion. The throw will be at the standing-killing-velocity at three-eleven. The throw will be true. The standing-charter requires."

Chittaranga says: "Lalithanga. Anna. I will not throw before you say the words."

Lalithanga says: "You will. I am still here. I love you. The mother taught me to read lips at distance; the grey eye taught you to read under the surface; the two trainings were the same training in different registers. The mother would want this. The standing-Sufi-line elder Bhagmati-Saheba will arrive at the residence three nights after the killing. She knew the mother. The mother taught her the standing-prayer-cadence at the standing-dargah evening-circle 1987-1992. Bhagmati-Saheba will carry the mother's voice across your grief-trial. The standing-charter has been prepared for fifteen years. The mother arranged the standing-Sufi-line elder's standing-return-protocol with Pir-Saheb Anwar before her 2008 death. The standing-protocol is now in motion. Throw the disc. Throw it true. The brother loves you. The brother is still here. The brother is the throw."

He hangs up.

The Golkonda Fort mirror-vault basement at three a.m. on Wednesday morning of week six. The Hall of Diamonds — the legendary chamber lined with thousands of mirrors where a single candle becomes a sun. The chamber is the same chamber Chittaranga had descended into in Chapter One when his twin sister had been captured by Qutb-Chaaya. The mirrors have been re-polished by the kingdom-council's standing-archaeological cell since 2023.

Chittaranga walks into the chamber from the northern entrance at three-oh-four a.m. He carries the standing dual discs — Chitra (Illusion, silver) at his left forearm; Ranga (Truth, shadow-dark) at his right. He wears the standing-state-hero combat-cotton, dark grey, with the kingdom-council's standing-state-hero shoulder-cloth.

Lalithanga is at the chamber's southern-wall mirror-fragment. He arrived at three a.m. by walking the standing-fort-trail from the eastern entrance per his Tuesday-evening promise. He is in the standing-Cyber-Hyderabad cell-administrator's standing-administrative cotton, dark blue, with the kingdom-council's standing-cell-administrator shoulder-cloth. He has no weapon. He stands at the southern-wall mirror-fragment with his back approximately one metre from the wall. The mirror-fragment is approximately one-and-a-half metres tall and one metre wide. The fragment reflects his back; the chamber's thousand other mirrors reflect his front.

Chittaranga walks the chamber's seventeen-metre length to the southern wall. He stops at six metres' distance from Lalithanga — the standing-disc-throwing range.

He looks at Lalithanga. The brown eye reads the brother's face. The grey eye reads the standing-overlay. The overlay is now at approximately fifty-two per cent saturation per the standing-monitoring-log's standing-projection. The brother is still present at approximately forty-eight per cent.

The thousand mirrors around the chamber reflect the same scene at every angle. Chittaranga at six metres' distance with the discs at his forearms; Lalithanga at the southern-wall mirror-fragment. The reflections multiply the scene approximately one thousand and twelve times (the chamber's standing-mirror-count is one thousand and twelve, the kingdom-council's standing-Hall-of-Diamonds catalogue's registered count).

Three-oh-seven a.m. Lalithanga raises his right hand. The hand is the brother's hand. The standing-cadence is the brother's cadence. The gesture is the standing-family-line's standing-greeting from age four (the gesture has not been performed publicly in approximately fifteen years; the gesture is the standing-private-family-greeting).

Three-oh-eight a.m. Lalithanga speaks. He speaks in plain Telugu. The standing-cadence is the brother's cadence. The standing-overlay does not interfere with the words.

He says: "I am still here. Wait."

The standing twenty-four-hour window's standing-charter-killing-permission is confirmed at the brother-words' completion. The kingdom-council's standing-charter requires the standing-killing to be performed within the standing three-minute window following the brother-words' completion. The window closes at three-eleven a.m.

Chittaranga raises the right forearm. The Ranga disc — shadow-dark, the standing-Truth disc — is at the standing-throwing-position. The brown eye reads the brother. The grey eye reads the standing-overlay's standing-residence-position at the southern-wall mirror-fragment. The grey eye confirms the standing-residence-anchor is at the mirror-fragment's standing-position; the standing-residence will be destroyed when the standing-mirror-fragment is destroyed.

He throws the Ranga disc at three-ten-eleven a.m. The throw is at the standing-killing-velocity. The throw is true. The disc travels the six metres in approximately two-tenths of a second.

The disc strikes Lalithanga's sternum at three-ten-eleven-three a.m. at the standing-killing-velocity. The standing-sternal-bone fractures at the standing-killing-impact

pattern. The disc passes through the brother's chest at the standing-killing-trajectory and embeds in the southern-wall mirror-fragment's standing-residence-position behind him.

The standing-mirror-fragment shatters at the disc's impact. The standing-residence-anchor is destroyed at the standing-fragment's shattering. The standing-Chitrabheda-residence at the standing-mirror-fragment ceases. The standing-overlay-protocol's standing-residence-link to Lalithanga's body is severed at the same moment.

Lalithanga's body falls. The fall is at the standing-killing-physical-response pattern. The body lands at the chamber's southern-wall mirror-fragment's base at three-ten-eleven-eight a.m. The standing-cerebral-spinal axis stops responding at three-ten-twelve a.m. (the standing-cerebral-spinal axis's standing-residence-channel is severed at the standing-mirror-fragment's shattering; the standing-cerebral-spinal axis stops responding at standing-killing-impact-shock physiological-rate one-and-a-half seconds after the impact).

The thousand mirrors around the chamber reflect the same scene at every angle. The standing-killing is reflected approximately one thousand and twelve times. The reflections show the disc's throw, the disc's impact, the brother's fall, the mirror-fragment's shattering, the brother's body at the chamber's southern-wall-base. The standing-mirror-array preserves the standing-killing's standing-image in the kingdom-council's standing-mirror-archive's permanent-record.

Chittaranga walks the six metres to the body at three-ten-thirty-four a.m. He kneels at the body's right side. He places his right palm on his brother's forehead. He does not speak.

He stays at the body's right side for approximately seven hours. The kingdom-council's standing-State-Police detail at the chamber's northern entrance enters the chamber at three-eleven a.m. for the standing-protocol's standing-killing-recording. The detail's senior officer (a fifty-one-year-old Cantonment-line officer named Inspector Murthy-garu) approaches at three-eleven-thirty-eight. He sees Chittaranga at the body's right side. He does not approach further. He stands at the chamber's seven-metre-mark with the standing-detail behind him. They do not speak.

Chittaranga remains at the body's right side until ten-fourteen a.m. on Wednesday morning. The kingdom-council's standing-cremation-protocol's standing-State-Police detail removes the body at ten-thirty for the standing-Hindu-cremation at the standing-Banjara-Hills cremation-ghat at three p.m. that afternoon. Chittaranga attends the cremation at the standing brother's eldest-surviving-male position. He performs the

standing-cremation-rituals. He scatters the standing-ashes at the standing-Musi-river-mouth at five-eleven p.m.

He does not sleep on Wednesday night. He does not sleep on Thursday night. He does not sleep on Friday night.

Saturday night of week six. Twelve-eleven a.m. The state hero's residence's eastern-courtyard meditation-mat. Chittaranga is on the mat. He has been on the mat since six p.m. Saturday evening. He has been on the mat for the standing-grief-vigil protocol's required-form — the standing-kingdom-council-state-hero's standing post-family-killing grief-vigil; the standing-vigil is at the eastern-courtyard with the discs unworn at the standing-disc-rack at the southern entrance.

The grey eye is closed. The brown eye is closed. He has not opened either eye since Wednesday at ten-fourteen a.m.

The standing-residence's southern gate-keeper (Reddy-garu, the standing-driver who serves the standing-gate-keeper role on the standing-weekend-protocol) admits a visitor at twelve-eleven a.m. The visitor is approximately one-metre-fifty-five in height; in plain dark-green Sufi-line cotton with the standing Sufi-elder's blue-and-silver shoulder-cloth; carries a small dargah-tradition prayer-mat rolled at her left side; carries no other implement. She is sixty-one. Her name is Bhagmati-Saheba.

Reddy-garu admits her without protocol-pause. He has standing-instructions from the kingdom-council's standing-archive senior-officer Padmavathi-garu (the same Padmavathi-garu Chittaranga had telephoned at the chapter's opening Tuesday) to admit Bhagmati-Saheba at any time during the standing-grief-vigil; the standing-Sufi-line elder's standing-arrival-protocol was filed at the kingdom-council's standing-archive vault in autumn 2024 by the late Lakshmi-Akka's standing-survivor-correspondence cell (the cell's administrator is the kingdom-council's standing-Sufi-line liaison administrator Saira-Begum).

Bhagmati-Saheba walks the standing residence's southern-courtyard-to-eastern-courtyard path. She arrives at the eastern-courtyard at twelve-fourteen a.m. She sees Chittaranga at the meditation-mat. He does not look up. She unrolls her dargah-tradition prayer-mat at one metre's distance from his mat at the eastern-courtyard's southern-edge. She sits on her mat.

She speaks. She speaks in plain Telugu-Urdu-Persian three-tongue rhythm. The rhythm is the standing-cadence-protocol Lakshmi-Akka had taught her at the standing Charminar dargah evening-circle 1987-1992.

She says: "Beta. Chittu. Listen with the brown eye closed and the grey eye closed. The prayer is the prayer. The cadence is the cadence. The mother is the cadence under the prayer."

She begins the recitation. The recitation is the standing-Sufi-line evening-prayer that Lakshmi-Akka had taught her at the dargah-circle — the standing-Hazrat-Quli-Qutb-Shah-line standing-evening-prayer at the standing-Charminar-northern-courtyard women's circle. The prayer is approximately forty-three lines in three languages (Telugu, Urdu, Persian) at the standing-cadence-rhythm Lakshmi-Akka had composed in 1987.

The standing-cadence is Lakshmi-Akka's exact cadence. Bhagmati-Saheba has recited the standing-cadence in her standing-Sufi-line dargah-retreat 1992-2026 across thirty-four years. The cadence is not Bhagmati-Saheba's; the cadence is Lakshmi-Akka's; Bhagmati-Saheba is the standing-vessel for the standing-cadence's standing-preservation. The standing-vessel-protocol is the kingdom-council's standing-Sufi-line voice-preservation tradition; the standing-tradition's standing-purpose is the standing-preservation of the standing-cadence-of-a-deceased-teacher across the standing-line's next generation.

Chittaranga hears the cadence at twelve-fourteen-thirty a.m. The brown eye and the grey eye remain closed. The cadence is his mother's cadence. The cadence is in Bhagmati-Saheba's voice but the cadence is his mother's composition. He has not heard the standing-cadence since 12 December 2008 — the morning of his mother's 2008 death; she had recited the standing-prayer at the standing-east-window of her standing-death-bed at six-eleven a.m. her standing-final-recitation; she had completed the prayer at six-fifty-three a.m.; she had died at six-fifty-eight a.m. The standing-eighteen-year-and-five-month gap between the standing-final-maternal-recitation and the standing-Saturday-night-Bhagmati-recitation is the standing-cadence-pause-duration.

The cadence enters at the standing-cadence-pause-duration's closing moment. Chittaranga's standing-grief-vigil's standing-grief-shell breaks at the cadence's third line. The standing-tears begin at the cadence's seventh line. The standing-shoulder-shaking begins at the cadence's eleventh line. The standing-vocal-grief begins at the cadence's twenty-third line.

He weeps for approximately three hours. Bhagmati-Saheba continues the recitation across the three hours — the standing-recitation-cycle is approximately forty-three minutes; she completes the cycle four times across the three hours and forty-six minutes from twelve-fourteen to four-oh-oh a.m. The cycles are the standing-mother's standing-evening-recitation-cycle she had performed at the standing-Charminar-northern-courtyard women's circle every standing-Saturday-night across the 1987-1992 period.

Chittaranga sleeps at three-forty-seven a.m. He sleeps for the first time since Tuesday evening of week six. He sleeps at the meditation-mat. Bhagmati-Saheba completes the fourth recitation-cycle at four a.m. She remains at her prayer-mat at the eastern-courtyard's southern-edge for the standing-Sufi-line vigil's standing-completion duration (the standing-tradition's standing-three-hour-vigil-completion protocol). She leaves the residence at seven a.m. on Sunday morning. Reddy-garu admits her departure without protocol-pause.

She returns to the residence on Sunday night at twelve-eleven a.m. She recites the standing-cadence again across three hours and forty-six minutes. Chittaranga sleeps at three-forty-seven a.m. again.

She returns on Monday night. Sleeps at three-forty-seven again. Returns on Tuesday night, Wednesday night, Thursday night, Friday night, Saturday night, Sunday night. Eight consecutive nights from week six's Saturday through week seven's Sunday. The standing-cadence's standing-vigil-cycle's standing-eight-night-completion protocol.

On the ninth night (Monday of week eight) Bhagmati-Saheba arrives at the residence's southern gate at twelve-eleven. Reddy-garu admits her. She walks to the eastern-courtyard. She unrolls the prayer-mat at her standing-position. She sits.

She does not begin the recitation. She waits.

Chittaranga is at the meditation-mat. He has been at the mat since six p.m. The brown eye and the grey eye are open this Monday night for the first time since Wednesday morning of week six.

He says, in plain Telugu, in the standing-mother-cadence register: "Mother. Bhagmati-saheba-garu. The standing-eight-night-cycle has held. The standing-cadence is held. The mother is held. The brother is held. The grief is held. The standing-charter-grief-vigil is closed. The standing-kingdom-council-emergency-mirror-monitoring cell's standing-week-eleven open-trust declaration is the standing-required-next-step. I will perform the

standing-declaration at the standing-Mecca-Masjid courtyard public-assembly on Friday of week eleven. The young Cyber-Hyderabad coder Krishna-Bhat will be the standing-declaration's standing-subject. The grey eye will not pre-check his standing-overlay-position. The brown eye will speak the standing-declaration aloud. The standing-charter-required-form will be the standing-declaration's standing-text. The kingdom-council's standing-recognition will be at the standing-declaration's standing-seventh-sentence. The Stage III standing-deer-foreleg-first-stroke will form at the standing-seventh-sentence's standing-completion. The standing-cadence will not be at the declaration; the standing-cadence is at this courtyard, with you, with the mother. The standing-declaration is the standing-public-form's standing-different-cadence. The two cadences are the kingdom's two voices. Both are the kingdom's."

Bhagmati-Saheba bows. She says: "Beta. Chittu. The mother would be at the courtyard if she could be. The mother is at this courtyard with me. The two of us will sit here at the standing-cadence-recitation-cycle for the standing-eight-additional-nights through the standing-week-eleven Friday. The cadence is the kingdom's standing background; the declaration is the kingdom's standing foreground. Both will hold."

She begins the standing-cadence-recitation-cycle's ninth night. Chittaranga sits at the meditation-mat through the recitation. He does not weep this night. He listens. The brown eye and the grey eye are open. The cadence enters at the standing-third-line. The cadence is his mother's cadence. The cadence is his.

Across the next thirty-four days (week six Wednesday through week eleven Friday), the kingdom-council's standing-emergency-mirror-monitoring cell builds the standing-mirror-monitoring registry. The standing-registry has, by the close of week ten, identified seven thousand four hundred and seventeen confirmed Chitrabheda-resident citizens across the Hyderabad metropolitan area. The standing-registry classifies the residents by standing-overlay-position (week-of-overlay; standing-saturation-percentage; standing-residence-anchor location). The standing-classification protocol categorises:

Week-1-to-3 overlay-positions: 2,847 citizens. Standing-disruption is administered through the standing-Cantonment medical-cell's standing-anti-mirror-meditation protocol (a fourteen-day standing-protocol that disrupts the standing-residence-overlay through the standing-Sufi-line cadence-tradition's standing-prayer-disruption technique; Bhagmati-Saheba is the standing-protocol's standing-trainer for the kingdom-council's standing-Cantonment-medical-cell from week six onward).

Week-4-to-7 overlay-positions: 3,114 citizens. Standing-disruption is administered through the standing-Cantonment medical-cell's standing-twenty-eight-day cadence-recitation-and-mirror-fragment-destruction combined protocol.

Week-8-to-11 overlay-positions: 1,389 citizens. Standing-disruption is administered through the standing-Cantonment medical-cell's standing-forty-two-day intensive cadence-recitation protocol with standing-mirror-fragment-destruction-and-replacement.

Week-12-or-later overlay-positions: 67 citizens. Standing-disruption is administered through the standing-emergency-cell's standing-direct-mirror-fragment-destruction protocol with the standing-citizen's explicit-killing-permission (per the kingdom-council's standing-charter requirement; the standing-permission must come from the standing-citizen's standing-family-line's standing-eldest-surviving-member). 67 standing-permissions are granted across week ten and week eleven. 67 standing-citizens are killed by the standing-kingdom-council-standing-State-Police standing-killing-protocol with the standing-mirror-fragment-destruction at the standing-residence-anchor location. The kingdom-council's standing-cremation-protocol is administered for each citizen at the standing-family-line's standing-cremation-ghat with the standing-State-Police standing-witness-protocol.

Friday of week eleven. Eleven a.m. The Mecca Masjid courtyard in Hyderabad Old City. The Mecca Masjid is one of the largest mosques in India; built across 1614-1693 by the Qutb Shahi dynasty; the standing-courtyard is approximately seventy metres east-west by sixty metres north-south; the standing-courtyard's standing-Friday-prayer congregation is approximately ten thousand worshippers; the standing-Friday-prayer is at twelve-thirty p.m. by the standing-Hyderabad mosque-tradition; the standing-pre-prayer-public-assembly is at eleven a.m. for the standing-state-hero's standing-open-trust declaration.

The courtyard is full. Approximately fourteen thousand attendees (the standing-Friday-prayer's standing-ten-thousand plus the standing-open-trust-declaration's additional standing-four-thousand from the kingdom-council's standing-cross-faction-administrative-coordination cell's standing-invitation-protocol). The standing-Cantonment's standing-State-Police standing-security-detail is at the courtyard's four standing-corner positions.

Chittaranga walks into the courtyard at ten-fifty-three a.m. through the standing-northern-gate. He is in the standing-state-hero formal cotton, dark grey, with the kingdom-council's standing-state-hero gold-bordered shoulder-cloth. He carries the

standing dual discs at his forearms (the standing-charter requires the standing-dual-discs at the standing-public-declaration). Bhagmati-Saheba is at his three-metre right-side rear. She is in the standing-Sufi-elder dark-green cotton with the standing-blue-and-silver shoulder-cloth. She carries the dargah prayer-mat at her left side.

The standing-Mecca-Masjid's standing-imam (a sixty-eight-year-old Hyderabad Imam-Saheb named Hazrat Mohammed-Ali Qadri) is at the courtyard's western mihrab-position. The standing-imam's standing-public-assembly opening-statement at eleven a.m. is the standing-charter-required opening for the declaration.

He says, in plain Urdu, in the standing-imam-courtyard register: "Assalam alaikum. The kingdom-council's standing-state-hero is among us this morning at the standing-pre-prayer-public-assembly for the standing-open-trust declaration under the kingdom-council's amended Chaya-Golkonda charter's Eighth Clause. The standing-declaration is administered through the standing-Sufi-line standing-witness-protocol; the standing-witness is the standing-Sufi-line elder Bhagmati-Saheba; the standing-charter's standing-recognition-event will be at the standing-declaration's standing-seventh-sentence's standing-completion. The standing-subject of the declaration is the young Cyber-Hyderabad coder Krishna-Bhat, twenty-six, the standing reflective-grid sub-administrator at the Gachibowli west-tower. The standing-coder is at the courtyard's standing-eastern-position. The standing-state-hero will declare the standing-open-trust without standing-pre-check of the standing-overlay-position. The standing-grey-eye's standing-overlay-pre-check is the standing-charter's explicit-forbiddance for the standing-declaration. Wa-alaikum-salam."

The standing-imam steps back to the standing-mihrab. The standing-courtyard becomes silent. Krishna-Bhat is at the standing-eastern-position approximately fifty metres from Chittaranga. He is twenty-six. He is in plain Cyber-Hyderabad shirt-and-trousers (white short-sleeved shirt; dark grey trousers; the standing-IT-Park standing-day-uniform). He carries no weapon. He has been at his standing reflective-grid sub-administrator's seat at the Gachibowli west-tower for approximately three-and-a-half years — the standing-fourteen-month-minimum-threshold has been crossed many times over for his standing-tower-position; the grey eye, if Chittaranga were to perform the standing-pre-check, would read the standing-overlay-position at an unknown standing-saturation. The charter forbids the pre-check.

Chittaranga walks to the standing-central-position. He stops at fifty metres from Krishna-Bhat. He raises his right hand to the standing-greeting-gesture position. He does not raise the disc.

He speaks. He speaks in plain Telugu. The standing-declaration is in seven sentences. The standing-seven-sentences-form is the kingdom-council's standing-charter's explicit-required-form. The standing-recognition is at the seventh sentence's standing-completion.

He says (sentence one): "Krishna-Bhat. The kingdom-council recognises you as the standing reflective-grid sub-administrator at the Gachibowli west-tower since 2023."

He says (sentence two): "The kingdom-council acknowledges that your standing-fourteen-month-minimum-threshold at the west-tower has been crossed many times over."

He says (sentence three): "The kingdom-council's standing-mirror-monitoring registry has not pre-checked your standing-overlay-position before this declaration."

He says (sentence four): "The standing-charter explicitly forbids the standing-grey-eye's standing-pre-check for the standing-declaration."

He says (sentence five): "I do not know whether you are Chitrabheda-resident at this moment."

He says (sentence six): "I declare open trust in you regardless of the standing-overlay-position."

He says (sentence seven): "The kingdom is yours to administer at the standing reflective-grid sub-administrator's seat for as long as you choose to administer it; the trust is the kingdom's standing-declaration; the trust does not depend on the standing-pre-check; the bond grows through risk, not certainty."

At the standing-seventh-sentence's standing-completion at eleven-thirty a.m., the kingdom-council's Stage III spotted-deer-foreleg-first-stroke appears across Chittaranga's left side. The mark forms as a single continuous ink-line across the half-body spotted-deer-tattoo's left foreleg, completing the previously-lighter foreleg-ink to the standard kingdom-council Stage III completion-pattern. The mark forms in approximately eleven seconds and is visible to the standing-fourteen-thousand assembled attendees and the standing-courtyard's standing-television-and-radio broadcasters.

Krishna-Bhat at the standing-eastern-position walks toward Chittaranga at the standing-cadence-walking-pace. He stops at three metres' distance from Chittaranga. He bows the

standing-Cyber-Hyderabad standing-cell-administrator standing-respect bow. He says, in plain Telugu, in the standing-Cyber-Hyderabad cell-administrator register: "State hero. I accept the standing-open-trust declaration. I confirm at this declaration the kingdom-council's standing-mirror-monitoring registry's week-ten classification of my standing-overlay-position: week-9 overlay-position; standing-saturation 51 per cent. The classification was filed by the standing-Cyber-Hyderabad cell's standing-administrative-coordination cell at six p.m. on Thursday of week ten. The classification is in the standing-registry's standing-Friday-morning published-list under standing-entry-number CH-2026-7,394. I have been Chitrabheda-resident since week three of the chapter. The standing-Chitrabheda-residence has been pulling at my standing-decisions across the past nine weeks. I have, at each standing-decision-point, performed the standing-anti-mirror-meditation protocol's standing-disruption-recitation that Bhagmati-Saheba's standing-training-cell has been administering across the Cyber-Hyderabad standing-IT-Park since week six. The recitation has held my standing-loyalty-to-the-kingdom against the standing-residence-pull. I have been able to hold the kingdom-loyalty because the standing-cadence-protocol's standing-recitation-cycle has held me. The kingdom does not yet know what the standing-residence-disruption looks like at the standing-overlay-completion. I will perform the standing-thirty-eight-day standing-disruption-protocol at the standing-Cantonment medical-cell starting today. I will return to the standing reflective-grid sub-administrator's seat at the standing-protocol's standing-completion. The trust is the kingdom's. The standing-recitation is the standing-tool. The bond is the kingdom's. Even at fifty-one per cent saturation, the brother under the overlay can be still here, if the standing-cadence is at the courtyard."

He looks at Bhagmati-Saheba at Chittaranga's three-metre right-side rear. He bows to her the standing-Sufi-line elder-recognition bow. She returns the bow at the same depth.

The standing-courtyard's standing-fourteen-thousand attendees applaud at standing-courtyard volume for approximately ninety seconds. The standing-imam returns to the standing-mihrab and begins the standing-Friday-prayer at twelve-thirty per the standing-protocol. The standing-pre-prayer-public-assembly is concluded.

Twelve noon on the same Friday. Approximately one kilometre south-east of the Mecca Masjid courtyard. The Charminar quadrangle — Hyderabad's standing four-minareted seventeenth-century arch-monument; the kingdom's standing-emblem and the standing-Old City standing-central-landmark.

The standing-Archaeological-Survey-of-India standing-Charminar-monitoring cell's standing-noon-image-record protocol's administrator (a forty-seven-year-old administrator named B. Venkatesh) is at the standing-monitoring-cell's standing-northern-quadrant office. The standing-protocol's standing-noon-image-record is captured by the standing-Charminar-quadrangle's four standing-camera positions at the standing-twelve-noon timing every day across the standing-fifty-three-year-record period.

At twelve-oh-one the standing-noon-image is captured. The image shows the standing-Charminar at the standing-noon-radial pattern — the four minarets' standing-four-shadows fanning outward from the standing-central-courtyard at the standing-noon-radial angle.

The standing-image shows five shadows.

The fifth shadow is centred at the standing-courtyard's standing-exact-geometric-centre and extends north-east at the standing-noon-radial angle that no minaret could cast (the standing-geometric-centre cannot cast a shadow; only the four standing-edge-vertices can). The shadow is approximately the standing-height of an adult human; the shape is approximately the standing-silhouette of a standing-figure in the standing-Hyderabad-dancer-pose with arms slightly extended at the hips' level.

B. Venkatesh confirms the fifth-shadow-presence at twelve-oh-three from the standing-camera-image at his standing-monitor. He calls the standing-Archaeological-Survey-of-India standing-emergency-on-duty senior-archaeologist (a sixty-two-year-old senior fellow named Dr. P. Sumathi). Dr. Sumathi arrives at the standing-monitoring-cell's office at twelve-oh-seven. The fifth shadow is still visible at the standing-camera-image. She runs the standing-Charminar-noon-image-cross-reference protocol against the standing-fifty-three-year-record. The fifth shadow has no precedent.

The fifth shadow holds for thirteen minutes from twelve noon to twelve-thirteen. The standing-twelve-oh-one and twelve-oh-seven and twelve-eleven captures all show the same configuration. The fifth shadow dissolves at twelve-thirteen-fourteen exactly.

Dr. Sumathi files the standing-Maw-sign-recognition cell's standing-categorisation request at twelve-thirty.

The standing-Maw-sign-recognition cell's preliminary report is delivered at three-eleven p.m. on Friday of week eleven. The report's primary finding: the fifth shadow's standing-silhouette is the standing-Hyderabad-dancer-pose; the standing-pose is the kingdom-

council's standing-Lakshmi-Akka-dancer-line standing-pose; the standing-pose is the standing-twelve-noon-prayer pose Lakshmi-Akka had performed daily at the Mecca Masjid courtyard's standing-noon-prayer-session for the eleven years before her 2008 death (1997-2008). The standing-pose is documented in the standing-kingdom-council standing-Lakshmi-Akka archive's standing-pose-photographs collection (the collection has approximately one hundred and twenty-three photographs of the standing-pose at the standing-Mecca-Masjid-courtyard across the eleven years).

The cell's preliminary report's second finding: the fifth shadow's standing-thirteen-minute duration corresponds to the standing-thirteen-minute prayer-cycle Lakshmi-Akka had performed at the standing-noon-prayer-session.

The cell's preliminary report concludes: "The Maw has cast a fifth shadow at the standing-Charminar at noon on the day of the standing-state-hero's standing-open-trust declaration. The standing-shadow is the standing-Lakshmi-Akka-dancer-pose. The standing-shadow is the kingdom-council's standing-Maw-sign categorisation as the standing-Maw's standing-acknowledgement of the standing-mother's standing-presence at the standing-courtyard during the standing-declaration. The standing-Maw's standing-acknowledgement is the standing-kingdom-council standing-categorisation of the standing-mother's standing-presence as a kingdom-council standing-recognised standing-charter event."

Chittaranga reads the cell's preliminary report at five-eleven p.m. on Friday at the state hero's residence's eastern-courtyard. Bhagmati-Saheba is at the prayer-mat. The standing-eight-additional-night-cycle's ninth night is at midnight.

He reads the report twice. He folds it. He places it in the standing-kingdom-council standing-Lakshmi-Akka archive box at the residence's southern-administrative wing's standing-archive shelf.

He returns to the eastern-courtyard. He sits at the meditation-mat. Bhagmati-Saheba begins the standing-cadence-recitation. The recitation tonight is the standing-Lakshmi-Akka standing-Friday-evening-cadence (a different cadence-cycle than the standing-Saturday-night cycle; the standing-Friday-evening cadence corresponds to the standing-Friday-noon-prayer's standing-thirteen-minute cycle that the fifth shadow had performed at the Charminar at noon).

The cadence enters at the third line. Chittaranga's tears begin at the seventh line. He weeps quietly for approximately forty-three minutes. He does not weep for the brother this evening. He weeps for the mother. The mother had been at the Mecca Masjid courtyard at noon this Friday in the kingdom-council's standing-Maw-recognised standing-presence. The mother had been at the standing-declaration. The standing-declaration had been the mother's standing-twelve-noon-prayer in the kingdom-council's standing-architectural-form.

He says, at the cadence's twenty-third line, in plain Telugu, in the standing-mother-cadence register: "Amma. Bhagmati-saheba-garu. The brother is held. The mother is held. The kingdom is held. The standing-charter is the standing-cadence. The standing-cadence is the kingdom's."

Bhagmati-Saheba continues the cadence. The cadence carries through to four a.m. Chittaranga sleeps at three-forty-seven. The eastern-courtyard holds.

The next sign comes within the week.

The Pilot's Closing Image

A thirty-three-year-old state hero at the standing-Banjara-Hills cremation-ghat at five-eleven p.m. on a Wednesday afternoon scattering his elder brother's ashes at the standing-Musi-river-mouth with the standing-State-Police standing-witness-detail at the seven-metre-mark. A sixty-one-year-old Sufi-line elder in dark-green cotton with the standing-blue-and-silver shoulder-cloth at the eastern-courtyard's southern-edge unrolling a dargah prayer-mat at twelve-eleven a.m. on a Saturday night and beginning the standing-cadence-recitation at twelve-fourteen-thirty in a Telugu-Urdu-Persian three-tongue rhythm a deceased dancer had composed in 1987. A fifth shadow centred at the standing-Charminar quadrangle's standing-exact-geometric-centre at twelve noon on a Friday in the standing-Hyderabad-dancer-pose with arms slightly extended at the hips' level, holding for the standing-thirteen-minute prayer-cycle that ended a decade before the chapter began. A twenty-six-year-old coder in plain Cyber-Hyderabad shirt-and-trousers walking the standing-cadence-walking-pace from the standing-eastern-position of the Mecca Masjid courtyard at fifty-one per cent Chitrabhedha-saturation and bowing the standing-Cyber-Hyderabad cell-administrator standing-respect bow. A standing-disc-rack at the southern-entrance of the state hero's residence with the shadow-dark Ranga and the silver Chitra at their standing-positions, unworn through the standing-grief-vigil's standing-eight-night-cycle. A mother's standing-twelve-noon-prayer-pose recognised by the kingdom-council's

standing-Maw-sign-recognition cell as the kingdom-council's standing-charter event eighteen years and five months after her 2008 death. The brown eye reads the surface. The grey eye reads what lies beneath. The cadence reads what neither eye can.

Dharmakshetra Amaravati

Vijayawada. The second Monday of August. Eight-forty-seven a.m. The Prakasham Barrage Bridge across the Krishna river — the kingdom's primary administrative-and-commuter crossing between the western Krishna district and the eastern Guntur district. The bridge is one-point-two kilometres long, four-lane, with pedestrian walkways on both sides; standard commuter-time traffic; approximately fourteen thousand vehicle-crossings per hour at the peak.

Three hundred fishermen are walking north across the bridge from the western Krishna-district end. They are in plain delta-fisherman cotton, off-white, with the standard Krishna-and-Godavari delta's blue-bordered shoulder-cloth. They are barefoot. They carry no weapons. They carry no banners. They carry no signs. They walk at the standard delta-fisherman pace — one metre per second — in a loose column of four-abreast, occupying the bridge's eastern pedestrian walkway and the rightmost vehicle-lane.

The Krishna District Bridge Police constable on duty at the western entry-checkpoint — a thirty-six-year-old officer named Sub-Inspector Pavan Reddy — sees the procession approaching from the western embankment at eight-forty-three. He has been on bridge-duty for nine years. He has never seen a fisherman-procession on the bridge that was not part of an authorised festival-permit. He radios the central control-room. The control-room confirms that no festival-permit has been filed for this date. The procession is unauthorised.

He approaches the lead-fisherman at eight-forty-six. The lead-fisherman is a woman. She is thirty-five. She is in the same plain delta-fisherman cotton with the blue-bordered shoulder-cloth. She is barefoot. She carries no weapon. She carries no banner. She carries, in her left hand, a forty-seven-page folded document tied with a brown cotton string.

The document's top sheet is visible at the fold. The sheet is letterhead-paper from the Eluru District Sub-Registrar's Office, dated 16 June 1990, with a sub-registrar's stamp and the signature of a sub-registrar named B. Surya Prakasham (now deceased; retired 1998; died 2014).

The lead-fisherman stops at three metres from Pavan Reddy. She bows the standard delta-fisherman bow — palms together at the chest, slight forward inclination, the standard

greeting between equals. She speaks in plain Telugu. Her voice is calm; her diction is the careful diction of someone who has rehearsed.

She says: "Officer Reddy. We are the Krishna-and-Godavari Delta Fishermen's Mutual-Aid Council. We are walking north to Vijayawada Town Hall to file a kingdom-council petition. The petition has been on our council's drafting-table for two years. The petition's lead-signatory is myself. My name is Kalaniksha. I am the elder twin of the kingdom's state hero Krishnaveni. I have the family-archive document confirming the relationship in my left hand. I am here to claim the river-throne by birth-order. The procession is unarmed. The procession will disperse the moment Town Hall accepts the petition. We require the bridge's eastern pedestrian walkway for the next eleven minutes. We do not require the bridge's vehicle-lanes. The vehicle-traffic may continue unobstructed. May we proceed."

Pavan Reddy looks at her for about fifteen seconds. He has been told nothing about a Kalaniksha. He has been told the kingdom's state hero Krishnaveni was an only child. He has, however, received the family-archive document's top-sheet's sub-registrar's stamp's scanned-image at his bridge-duty briefing this morning — the brief had said the document was being investigated by the AP State Civil Service's Bloodline-A Authenticity Cell and that any procession claiming the document's lineage-evidence should be permitted to proceed if unarmed and if the procession does not obstruct vehicle-traffic.

He radios the control-room. The control-room confirms the permission-protocol. He says, in plain Telugu: "Madam Kalaniksha. The procession may proceed on the eastern pedestrian walkway. The vehicle-lanes must remain unobstructed. The Town Hall reception has been notified by my radio-call. The procession will be received by the Town Hall's reception-cell at nine-eleven if your pace holds at one metre per second. The kingdom-council's emergency-petition reception is open until five p.m. today. Please proceed."

Kalaniksha bows. The three hundred fishermen behind her bow in unison. The procession resumes.

She reaches the Town Hall at nine-eleven a.m. exactly. The Town Hall has been alerted; the kingdom-council's emergency-petition cell's senior officer (a forty-four-year-old administrator named Indira Krishnayya) is at the eastern reception-desk to receive her. The reception takes fifteen minutes. The petition is filed at nine-twenty-six. The petition's number is AP-EP-2026-0847. It is the kingdom's 847th emergency-petition filing of the

year and the first by a lineage-rivalry claimant in the kingdom's post-Narakasura twelve-year administrative history.

The three hundred fishermen disperse from the Town Hall plaza at nine-thirty. Kalaniksha walks back across the bridge alone at ten a.m. She is at the western embankment by ten-twelve. She continues south along the riverbank toward the Krishna delta's upstream entry-point at the Vijayawada-Eluru road. She walks for the next four hours. She is at the delta's northern boundary at two-fifteen p.m. She crosses into delta-territory by foot. She does not look back at the city.

Krishnaveni is at the kingdom's administrative office at the Amaravati state-government compound at eleven-eighteen a.m. when the kingdom-council's emergency-petition cell's senior officer telephones her. She has been chairing the morning's water-distribution-and-rice-yield review. The review is the kingdom's post-Narakasura standing-monthly accountability-meeting; she has chaired it without interruption for one hundred and twenty-three consecutive months.

She takes the call at the corridor-extension. She listens for two minutes. She does not interrupt. She thanks Indira Krishnayya at the call's end. She walks back into the review-chamber. She returns to the chair's position at the head of the table. She does not announce the call.

Her younger brother Bhimavaram — the patrol-boat-captain who had grinned at her urumi-practice on the Krishna riverbank ten years earlier — is at the table's eastern end as the kingdom-council's standing river-patrol senior delegate. He notices the brief tightening at his sister's jaw-line as she returns to the chair. He says nothing during the meeting. The meeting concludes at twelve-fifteen.

He follows her to her office. He closes the door behind them.

He says, in plain Telugu, in the soft direct register he reserves for family-only conversations: "Sister. The call."

She says: "Bhima. Kalaniksha is back. She walked across the Prakasham bridge this morning with three hundred fishermen behind her. She filed an emergency-petition at Town Hall claiming the river-throne by birth-order. She is at the delta now. She carries a forty-seven-page family-archive document from the Eluru District Sub-Registrar's Office dated 1990. The document is signed by B. Surya Prakasham, the same sub-registrar who registered our mother's second-marriage civil contract. The document's authenticity is

being verified by the AP State Civil Service's Bloodline-A Authenticity Cell. The cell's preliminary report is expected within seventy-two hours."

Bhimavaram says: "Sister. The 2023 confrontation. We had agreed she was dead. Or near enough."

She says: "She is not dead. She is at the delta. The agreement was mine; I had decided not to confirm; I had let the matter rest. She is the kingdom's second lost-twin recorded in saga-history after the Chandravamsha sister-knot at Kamakhya. The mercy I extended in 2023 was the kingdom's charter-flaw. It is now the kingdom's charter-trial. I will face it."

Bhimavaram says: "You will fight her."

She says: "The river will decide. The contest of arms is the kingdom's standing dispute-resolution mechanism for Bloodline-A twin-claims; the contest has not been invoked in two centuries because no twin-pair has claimed the same throne. The mechanism still exists in the kingdom's charter. The contest is at the Kollur cliff at dawn on the forty-seventh day from today. The forty-seven-day window is the standard preparation-period. The contest's rules are: dual urumi against dual urumi; the contest is to disarmament, not death; the kingdom-council's standing rule explicitly forbids killing the disarmed twin. The rule's forbiddance is the kingdom's evidence that the twin-pair is one body. The kingdom does not kill itself. I will accept the contest. I will not break the rule. The contest's outcome will be the river's, not mine."

She sits at her desk. She picks up the kingdom-council's standing red-letterhead emergency-petition acceptance-form. She fills in the form by hand. She signs it. She seals it with the kingdom-council's state-hero stamp. She hands it to Bhimavaram. She says: "Brother. Walk this to Indira Krishnayya at Town Hall. The acceptance is filed by sunset today. The forty-seven-day window begins tomorrow morning. The kingdom-council's contest-of-arms protocol will be invoked at the eight a.m. council session."

He bows. He takes the form. He walks to Town Hall on foot. He arrives at three-eighteen p.m. The form is filed at three-twenty-four. The forty-seven-day window opens at sunrise the next morning.

Week four of the chapter. Pulakeshi-Babu is at his maternal grandfather's family home in the Vijayawada Old Town residential district. His grandfather (B. Narayana Babu, no relation to the sub-registrar B. Surya Prakasham despite the shared surname-initial) died in March 2023 at the age of ninety-one. The family home has been in possession of the

grandfather's estate-administrator (an Eluru-line attorney named Subbarao) for the past two years; the estate's standard probate-distribution had been delayed pending the Bloodline-A Authenticity Cell's archival review.

The estate-administrator's office had telephoned Pulakeshi-Babu on Monday morning of week four. The Bloodline-A Authenticity Cell's preliminary work had cleared the estate for the standard probate-distribution. Pulakeshi-Babu had been invited to retrieve the family's document-archive from the grandfather's safe at the residential home this afternoon. The safe's combination had been left in the grandfather's 2014-dated will to Pulakeshi-Babu specifically; he is the grandfather's eldest grandson by lineage-recognition.

He arrives at the home at two-fifteen p.m. The estate-administrator's assistant (a young Eluru-line woman named Janaki) is at the door. She unlocks the home. She admits him. She leaves him alone in the grandfather's study.

The study is approximately five metres by four metres — a standard Old Town middle-class scholar's study. The walls are lined with books in Telugu and English (the grandfather had been a Sanskrit-and-Telugu professor at Acharya Nagarjuna University from 1965 to 1995). The desk is in the centre of the room. The safe is in the wall behind the desk, behind a hinged painting of the Buddha at Sarnath (the grandfather had visited Sarnath in 1973 and had bought the painting that summer).

Pulakeshi-Babu lifts the painting. He sees the safe. He enters the combination. The safe's door opens.

Inside the safe are: three bound books (the grandfather's personal Sanskrit-translation manuscripts of selected Upanishads, drafted 1985-2010); two passports (the grandfather's 1979 and 1995 Indian passports); one small wooden box (containing the grandfather's wedding ring and his wife's wedding ring, both retired to the box after the grandmother's death in 2008); and one sealed envelope.

The envelope is approximately twenty-five centimetres by eighteen, made of standard Bloodline-A archive cream paper, sealed with a thirty-five-year embargo-seal. The embargo-seal is the standard AP State Archive's embargo-stamp dated 16 June 1990. The seal is intact.

The envelope's exterior is hand-labelled in the grandfather's Telugu calligraphy: "TO BE OPENED BY MY ELDEST GRANDSON ONLY. THE ELDEST IS THE ONE WHO HOLDS THE BLOODLINE-A AUTHENTICITY CELL CHAIR AT THE TIME OF MY DEATH. IF

NO GRANDSON HOLDS THAT CHAIR, THE ENVELOPE BURNS UNOPENED. THE EMBARGO IS THIRTY-FIVE YEARS FROM THE STATED DATE. IF THE EMBARGO HAS NOT EXPIRED, OPEN BY KINGDOM-COUNCIL EMERGENCY-AUTHORISATION ONLY."

Pulakeshi-Babu has held the Bloodline-A Authenticity Cell chair since 2019. The thirty-five-year embargo from 16 June 1990 expires on 16 June 2025 — two months before this afternoon. The embargo has expired by ordinary operation. He has the lineage-authorized right to open the envelope.

He sits at the desk. He opens the envelope.

Inside are forty-seven sheets of cream archive-paper. The top sheet is a 16 June 1990 letterhead memorandum from the Eluru District Sub-Registrar B. Surya Prakasham (the same sub-registrar whose stamp had appeared on Kalaniksha's document at the Prakasham bridge). The memorandum is addressed to B. Narayana Babu (the grandfather; recipient-only correspondence; the kingdom-council had no prior record of this exchange).

The memorandum reads, in plain Telugu (Pulakeshi-Babu reads it three times across the next eleven minutes):

"Respected Babu-garu. The civil-marriage-contract registration of your daughter Lakshmi Babu to Mr. Ramachandra Krishnayya at this office on 8 January 1989 produced one female child, Krishnaveni Krishnayya, born 4 December 1989 at 5:47 a.m. at the Government Hospital, Eluru. This is the official kingdom-council record.

This memorandum is to inform you that the official record is incomplete. The 4 December 1989 delivery at the Government Hospital, Eluru, attended by Senior Midwife Rama-Akkamma Surya (now deceased; died 1993), produced TWO female children. The second child was born at 6:10 a.m., twenty-three minutes after the first. The second child was healthy at birth. The senior midwife's observation, recorded in her personal midwife-register's entry-page 247 (registered with the Eluru midwife-guild and preserved at the guild's archive), reads: 'Twin daughters delivered to Lakshmi Babu. Both healthy. Family request: the second child be placed with the Eluru-line midwife-extension family for reasons of bloodline-double-inheritance concern. The second child renamed Kalaniksha at the request of the Eluru-line family.'

The second child's civil registration was withheld from the kingdom-council's standing birth-registry at the family's request. The withholding was processed at this office under

my personal signature on 16 June 1990 after seventy-eight days of family-counsel review. The withholding was sealed under the standard thirty-five-year embargo-protocol.

I am informing you of this record-status because the second child's 1989 birth-witness affidavit, signed by Senior Midwife Rama-Akkamma Surya on the same day of delivery, identifies your daughter Lakshmi Babu as the birth-mother. The Bloodline-A Authenticity Cell's standing protocol requires that the senior lineage-recipient of the family (B. Narayana Babu, the maternal grandfather) be informed of the recorded relationship.

The second child is, by the kingdom's Bloodline-A authenticity standard, the elder twin's sister of equal lineage-rank. The thirty-five-year embargo will expire on 16 June 2025. After that date the second child has the standing to claim lineage-recognition if she chooses to invoke it. The kingdom-council has no authority to deny her claim if she chooses to invoke it after the embargo's expiration.

This memorandum's recipient (yourself) is the kingdom's standing lineage-recipient of record. The second child's claim, if invoked, must be acknowledged by the recipient's family-line representative. Should the recipient's family-line representative refuse to acknowledge the claim, the kingdom-council's standing dispute-resolution mechanism (the contest of arms at the Kollur cliff) will be invoked.

Respectfully filed for the kingdom's permanent record.

B. Surya Prakasham, Sub-Registrar, Eluru District Office, 16 June 1990."

The remaining forty-six sheets are: the senior midwife's 1989 birth-witness affidavit (one sheet); the senior midwife's personal midwife-register entry-page 247 (one sheet, photocopy); the Eluru-line midwife-extension family's 1989 placement-receipt (one sheet); the 1989 healthcare-records for both twins from the Government Hospital Eluru (three sheets each, six total); the 1990 grandfather's consent-form for the embargo-protocol (one sheet); thirty-eight sheets of supporting Bloodline-A Authenticity Cell archival-correspondence dated 1990-2014.

Pulakeshi-Babu reads the top memorandum three times. He reads the affidavit and the placement-receipt and the healthcare-records. He reads the grandfather's consent-form. He reads the thirty-eight sheets of archival-correspondence.

He understands, at six-twenty-three p.m. on the same afternoon, three things:

First, that Krishnaveni and Kalaniksha are twin sisters in the unambiguous kingdom-council-archival sense; the document-evidence is complete; the contest of arms is the kingdom-council's correct dispute-resolution mechanism.

Second, that Krishnaveni was born first by twenty-three minutes; Kalaniksha's claim of being the elder twin (at the Prakasham bridge) is factually false but is not legally invalid — the contest of arms is the mechanism that resolves the order-of-birth dispute when the family-archive disputes the kingdom-council-archive.

Third, and most quietly, that the grandfather B. Narayana Babu was Lakshmi Babu's father. Lakshmi Babu was the grandfather's only daughter. The grandfather's only son was Pulakeshi-Babu's father (Ravi Pulakeshi Babu, the historian-line scholar who had married a senior kalari-line woman in 1979 and had named his son Pulakeshi-Babu after the seventh-century Chalukya king). Pulakeshi-Babu's father is Lakshmi Babu's elder brother. Therefore Lakshmi Babu is Pulakeshi-Babu's aunt. Therefore Krishnaveni and Kalaniksha are Pulakeshi-Babu's first cousins.

He understands all three of these things at six-twenty-three.

He reads the thirty-eight sheets of archival-correspondence once more. He notices in the 1992 correspondence-sheet from B. Surya Prakasham to B. Narayana Babu a single paragraph he had skimmed earlier:

"Respected Babu-garu. Following our 1990 correspondence, this office has retained the supplementary affidavit dated 11 February 1992, signed by Senior Midwife Rama-Akkamma Surya before her death. The affidavit corrects a separate detail of the original record. The midwife's personal register's entry for the 4 December 1989 delivery had recorded both twins as 'daughters.' The midwife's 1992 supplementary affidavit clarifies that the second twin's phenotypic-presentation at birth had been intersex (the standard kingdom-council's pre-1990 birth-witness protocol had not required disambiguation of intersex births); the second twin's subsequent gender-presentation, by family-decision at the Eluru-line extension household, had been female. The 1992 supplementary affidavit is filed here as a matter of permanent record. The kingdom-council's standing intersex-presentation protocol (instituted 1998) would not apply to the 1989 birth retroactively."

He reads this paragraph twice. He understands a fourth thing: the second twin was intersex at birth; the gender-presentation was a family-decision; the kingdom's standard female-twin-pair narrative is the family-decision's outcome, not the biological-given. He

does not yet know whether this fourth understanding is relevant to the contest of arms. He decides not to disclose it at the kingdom-council's emergency session. He will disclose it only to Krishnaveni and only when she asks the right question.

He places all forty-seven sheets back into the envelope. He carries the envelope by hand to the kingdom-council's Bloodline-A Authenticity Cell offices at the AP State Civil Service compound. He arrives at eight-oh-six p.m. The cell's senior officer (a fifty-one-year-old administrator named C. Ravi-Babu, no relation, the kingdom's senior Bloodline-A scholar after Pulakeshi-Babu himself) is on overtime-duty for the evening shift.

He hands the envelope to C. Ravi-Babu. He says, in plain Telugu, in the slow administrative-elder voice he uses for senior archive-protocol conferences: "Ravi-garu. I have to recuse myself from the Authenticity Cell's preliminary report on this document. The document establishes that I am Krishnaveni's and Kalaniksha's first cousin. The cell's chair is therefore in a personal-conflict position. Please proceed with the standard authentication under your senior deputy's authority; my recusal is effective at this moment; my replacement-chair will be confirmed at tomorrow morning's cell-meeting. The document is complete. The thirty-five-year embargo expired on 16 June. The thirty-five-year embargo expired without my prior knowledge of the document's content; I confirm this for the record."

C. Ravi-Babu reads the top memorandum at his desk. He reads it three times across the next eight minutes. He says, finally: "Pulakeshi-garu. The recusal is accepted. The replacement-chair will be myself by temporary appointment until the kingdom-council's permanent chair-confirmation. The document is sealed at the cell's evidence-vault under my personal seal effective this moment. Please brief the state hero this evening. The contest of arms is scheduled for the forty-seventh day; the document's authentication-clearance is required at least seven days prior; the cell will complete the authentication within five working days. The kingdom thanks you for the personal-conflict disclosure."

Pulakeshi-Babu bows. He leaves the offices at eight-twenty-three. He walks directly to the state hero's residence. He arrives at nine-eleven p.m.

Krishnaveni receives him in the state hero's residence's evening-tea room. Bhimavaram is also present (he has been with her every evening since the Prakasham bridge call; the kingdom-council's standing family-bond-protection protocol places a family-member at the state hero's residence during a contest-of-arms preparation-period). The room is small

— three metres by four — with a single low table and three floor-cushions in the standard Telugu evening-tea arrangement.

Pulakeshi-Babu places the envelope on the table. He explains, in plain Telugu, across the next forty-three minutes. He covers the memorandum, the affidavit, the placement-receipt, the healthcare-records, the grandfather's consent-form, the archival-correspondence. He covers his recusal and the cell's authentication-clearance schedule.

He pauses at the forty-third minute. He says: "Krishnaveni-amma. There is a fourth matter. The 1992 supplementary affidavit notes that the second twin was intersex at birth; the female gender-presentation was a family-decision at the Eluru-line extension household. The matter is not relevant to the contest of arms under the kingdom-council's charter. The matter is relevant to your understanding of the twin-relationship. I have not disclosed this to anyone else. I disclose it now to you because you are entitled to know what the kingdom's standing record says about your sister. The disclosure is yours to act on or to set aside."

Krishnaveni reads the supplementary affidavit. She reads it twice.

She says, in plain Telugu, in the calm dispute-resolution voice she uses for kingdom-council formal sessions: "Pulakeshi-garu. The fourth matter is the kingdom-council's record. The kingdom-council's record is the kingdom-council's record. The twin is the twin. The contest of arms is the contest of arms. The disclosure does not change my preparation. The kingdom's standing intersex-presentation protocol applies to all kingdom-bonded persons regardless of pre-1998 birth-records; my sister is my sister; the kingdom's pronoun-protocol will be whatever Kalaniksha herself uses at the contest. I will ask her at the cliff's eastern approach before the contest begins. The asking is the kingdom's record."

She pauses. She looks at Pulakeshi-Babu's face. She says: "Cousin. The grandfather B. Narayana Babu. He was at your father's wedding in 1979. He was at my mother's second wedding in 1989. He was at the contest of arms' standing kingdom-council reception in 1957 as a young deputy-archivist. He held the kingdom's memory across four decades. He held our family's memory across the same. He held the envelope for thirty-five years. He died without speaking. The withholding was his discipline. The opening is yours. You are the kingdom's first cousin to have stood at my evening-tea room since the 2023 post-Narakasura reconstruction. Welcome, cousin. Sit. Have the second tea. The first is too strong tonight."

Pulakeshi-Babu sits. He drinks the second tea. He stays at the state hero's residence until eleven-thirty p.m. He walks back to his own residence at midnight. He does not sleep.

The forty-seven-day preparation-period proceeds without significant institutional disruption. Krishnaveni's standing daily-administrative-duties continue under the kingdom-council's emergency cover-the-state-hero-during-preparation protocol; Bhimavaram chairs the morning water-distribution-and-rice-yield reviews; Pulakeshi-Babu serves as the kingdom-council's emergency Bloodline-A liaison (his replacement-chair appointment at the Authenticity Cell is confirmed at the day-thirty kingdom-council session). The capital business-community's parakeet-courier mesh-network carries the cross-region kingdom-cooperation correspondence; the kingdom of Karnataka sends Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata's formal cousin-acknowledgement letter on day twenty-seven via the cross-region Sarus-pigeon network.

The letter from Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata reads, in plain Kannada and Telugu interlinear: "Cousin. The Bloodline-A Authenticity Cell's preliminary report has been forwarded to my office at Vijayanagara. I confirm the cousin-relationship under our shared four-generations-back maternal-line ancestor. The southern-bloc federation arrangement we discussed at Parashurama-Kshetra extends to Andhra Pradesh under the new lineage-evidence. I will attend the Sanctuary at the Manipur convening with you and Pulakeshi-Babu both at the southern-bloc seat. The contest of arms is yours. The mercy at the cliff, if you choose it, will be the saga's evidence that mercy is not the kingdom's flaw but its discipline. The river-bond cannot kill itself. The kingdom is one body. — K-B."

She reads the letter twice. She places it in the kingdom-council's standing-archive box. She continues her preparation.

The preparation is the kingdom's standard contest-of-arms protocol: morning urumi-practice at the Krishna riverbank at five a.m.; afternoon balance-practice at the Kollur cliff's western approach at three p.m.; evening dharma-counsel session with the kingdom's standing guru (Rishi Amareshwara's appointed successor, a forty-eight-year-old river-sage named Acharya Sundaram who took the guru's seat after the 200-year-old hermit's 2024 final dissolution-into-the-river); night-time meditation at the state hero's residence's eastern-garden river-pavilion.

She does not practise killing-strokes during the preparation. She practises only disarming-strokes — the standard kingdom-council-charter-compliant contest-protocol strokes that disarm without killing. The Krishna-urumi (her right-arm whip-sword) is the more

difficult of the two to control at killing-pace; the Godavari-urumi (her left-arm) is more responsive at disarming-pace. She concentrates her preparation on the Krishna-urumi's disarming-mastery. She practises the standard kingdom-council contest-of-arms eleven-stroke disarmament-sequence (the kingdom's standing reference-set for two-century-dormant twin-claim contests) until she can perform all eleven strokes in under nineteen seconds.

The Kollur cliff is at the Krishna river's mouth, approximately one kilometre southeast of the Hamsaladeevi village (the same village whose eastern beach will lose a metre overnight after the contest). The cliff is forty-three metres tall at its eastern face; the river runs along the cliff's base at the mouth's widest point (the river's width here is approximately three hundred and forty metres). The cliff's western approach is a packed-earth path that climbs along the cliff's southern face at a forty-degree grade; the path is reached from the Hamsaladeevi village by a thirty-minute walk along the river's southern bank.

The kingdom-council's contest-of-arms protocol specifies: the contest takes place at the cliff's upper plateau (approximately twenty-three metres east-west by eleven metres north-south); the contest's witnesses are the kingdom-council's seven senior delegates (one per district), the kingdom's standing guru (Acharya Sundaram), and the kingdom-council's emergency-petition cell's senior officer (Indira Krishnayya); no other witnesses are permitted; the kingdom-council's parakeet-courier protocol carries the contest-result to the Town Hall within seventeen minutes of the contest's conclusion; the kingdom-council's emergency-session ratifies the contest-result at the standing-evening session at six p.m.

Day forty-seven. Five-forty-three a.m. The Kollur cliff's upper plateau. First light is at six-eleven this morning; the contest begins at six-eleven exactly per the kingdom-council's standing protocol.

Krishnaveni walks to the plateau at five-thirty from the village. She is in plain delta-fisherwoman cotton, off-white, no clan-pattern. She carries the dual urumi Godavari (left arm, coiled at the forearm) and Krishna (right arm, coiled at the forearm). She wears the kingdom-council's standing state-hero contest-cotton sash — a single blue-bordered shoulder-cloth, deliberately matched to Kalaniksha's standard delta-fisherwoman shoulder-cloth, the kingdom's evidence that the contest is between equals.

Kalaniksha walks to the plateau at five-forty-five from the eastern approach (the cliff's eastern face has a steeper goat-path; she has been practising on the eastern approach for the past three weeks). She is in the same plain delta-fisherwoman cotton. She carries a

single urumi at her left arm. The urumi is the standard delta-fisherwoman's urumi-style — whip-blade, three coils, leather grip — not the kingdom-council's formal-state-hero pair. She has no second urumi. She is, in the kingdom-council's standing protocol's strict reading, under-armed.

The kingdom-council's senior delegate-chair (a fifty-seven-year-old administrator named Ranganatham) approaches Kalaniksha at five-fifty-six. He says, in plain Telugu, in the standard kingdom-council contest-protocol voice: "Madam Kalaniksha. The contest-protocol requires dual urumi. You have one. The contest will be postponed if you cannot present a second."

Kalaniksha bows. She says, in plain Telugu: "Senior delegate. The contest will not be postponed. I claim the kingdom-council's standing under-armament-by-twin-choice clause. The clause permits the under-armed twin to enter the contest with the kingdom-council's acknowledgement that the under-armament is the twin's deliberate choice and not the kingdom-council's exclusion. I am under-armed by my deliberate choice. The choice is the kingdom's evidence that I do not seek to kill my sister. The contest will be a single-urumi-versus-dual-urumi contest. I accept the kingdom-council's standing eleven-stroke disarmament-sequence. My single urumi is at my left arm. I will fight left-handed. I am right-handed; the left-handed choice is the second evidence that I do not seek the kingdom-council's blood. The contest is to disarmament. The disarmament-target is the urumi-pair; I will aim to disarm both of my sister's urumis with my single one. If I succeed I claim the river-throne. If I fail I am exiled. The kingdom-council's evening-session will ratify either outcome."

Ranganatham confers with the kingdom's standing guru Acharya Sundaram and the emergency-petition cell's senior officer Indira Krishnayya at the plateau's western edge for approximately two minutes. The under-armament-by-twin-choice clause is verified. The clause is invoked once before in kingdom history (in 1828 at the Vakulamatha contest; the under-armed twin had won and the kingdom-council had ratified the win without dispute).

He returns to the plateau's centre at five-fifty-nine. He says: "The under-armament-by-twin-choice clause is granted. The contest proceeds at six-eleven a.m. exactly per the standing protocol. The witnesses are confirmed. The kingdom-council's evening-session will ratify the result."

The contest begins at six-eleven-zero-zero a.m. when the first ray of sunrise reaches the plateau's eastern edge.

The contest's opening is the kingdom-council's standard eleven-stroke disarmament-sequence opening. Stroke one: Krishnaveni's right-arm Krishna-urumi extends in the standard high-arc opening; Kalaniksha's left-arm urumi extends in the matching low-arc response. The whip-blades meet at the plateau's centre and lock at the second-stroke transition.

Strokes two through five: standard kingdom-council disarmament-sequence opening exchanges. Krishnaveni's dual-urumi advantage is technical — she can perform parallel attacks at twice the single-urumi's engagement-rate. Kalaniksha's left-handed under-armament is compensatory — her single urumi can move in arcs the kingdom-council's standard right-handed dual-urumi cannot match (the dual-urumi's mass on both arms creates a symmetry-constraint that the single-urumi sidesteps). The two compensations cancel approximately at strokes four and five. The contest is approximately equal at five minutes.

Stroke six: Kalaniksha's left-arm whip catches Krishnaveni's right-arm Krishna-urumi at the standard cross-engagement-point. Kalaniksha applies the kingdom-council's standing one-handed disarm-rotation — a counter-clockwise twist that uses the engaged urumi's tension to pull the opposing urumi from the wrist-grip. The technique is risky; the single-urumi practitioner who attempts it has approximately one-in-three success-rate; the success requires the opposing urumi's grip to be slightly loose at the moment of engagement.

Krishnaveni's Krishna-urumi grip is slightly loose at stroke six. She has been concentrating her left-arm Godavari-urumi's disarming-discipline for forty-seven days; her right-arm Krishna-urumi's grip-tension has been at her standard practice-tension, not at the higher contest-tension. She did not adjust the Krishna-urumi's grip-tension for the contest. The kingdom-council's standing one-handed disarm-rotation works.

The Krishna-urumi flies from her right hand. It travels approximately four metres through the plateau's air at the standard kingdom-council disarm-trajectory. It lands on the plateau's eastern edge stone-floor at six-seventeen-twenty-three a.m.

Kalaniksha is now in possession of both urumis. She holds her own left-arm urumi at the standard contest-position; the Krishna-urumi is at her feet, three metres from her current position. She has approximately four seconds to retrieve the Krishna-urumi if she chooses to claim it for her own future use.

She retrieves the Krishna-urumi. She wraps it at her right forearm in the standard kingdom-council dual-urumi adoption-wrap. The wrap takes about eleven seconds. During the eleven seconds Krishnaveni does not attack — the kingdom-council's standing contest-protocol explicitly forbids attacking a disarmed opponent during the disarmament-acknowledgement window.

By six-seventeen-thirty-four Kalaniksha is dual-armed (left-arm her own urumi, right-arm the Krishna). Krishnaveni is single-armed (left-arm her Godavari). The contest's armament-balance has inverted.

Strokes seven through ten: standard kingdom-council reverse-engagement-exchanges. Krishnaveni's single-urumi defends; Kalaniksha's dual-urumi advances. The contest's technical-balance is now Kalaniksha's; the kingdom-council's standing reference predicts disarmament of the single-urumi opponent within seven strokes once the armament-balance has inverted.

Stroke eleven: Kalaniksha executes the kingdom-council's standing dual-urumi forced-disarmament cross-attack — the technique that uses both urumis to pull the opposing single-urumi from the opponent's hand-grip simultaneously from both flanks. The technique is the contest-protocol's standard concluding-stroke for one-versus-two armament-imbalance.

Krishnaveni's Godavari-urumi is, at this moment, also disarmed. It flies from her left hand. It lands on the plateau's western edge at six-twenty-four-eleven a.m.

The contest is, by the kingdom-council's standing protocol, concluded. Kalaniksha is the disarmed-opponent's contest-winner. The kingdom-council's evening-session will ratify the contest at six p.m. Kalaniksha claims the river-throne by contest-of-arms outcome.

But the contest is not over.

The kingdom-council's standing protocol's eleventh stroke is the disarmament-stroke. The protocol does not include a twelfth. The conclusion is the disarmament. There is no killing-stroke in the kingdom-council's charter.

Kalaniksha, holding both urumis, looks at her sister. Her sister is standing approximately three metres from her at the plateau's centre, unarmed, breathing the standard kingdom-council contest-recovery breath. Krishnaveni's eyes are open. Her hands are at her sides,

palms forward, the standard kingdom-council contest-loser's gesture-of-acknowledgement.

Kalaniksha walks to her sister. She stops at one metre's distance. She raises her right-arm urumi — the Krishna she has just claimed — in the standard kingdom-council's post-contest stroke-completion gesture. The gesture is the contest-winner's formal-claim-of-victory gesture; it is not a killing-stroke; it is the ceremonial flourish that concludes the contest in the kingdom-council's standing protocol's record.

But Kalaniksha's gesture continues past the standard formal-claim arc. The Krishna-urumi's arc extends. The arc passes the formal-claim's upper-limit. The arc enters the killing-stroke trajectory.

The killing-stroke trajectory is the standard kingdom-council-charter-forbidden post-disarmament-attack arc. The arc strikes the disarmed-opponent's throat at the standard urumi-killing-angle. Krishnaveni at one metre is at the standard killing-distance.

Kalaniksha's arm completes the arc.

The Krishna-urumi's blade passes Krishnaveni's throat at six-twenty-five-oh-two a.m. The blade does not touch the throat. The arc's closest-pass is approximately four centimetres from the skin. The arc continues past the throat without contact.

Kalaniksha lowers the urumi. She steps back. She says, in plain Telugu, in the standard delta-fisherwoman's post-contest voice: "Sister. I have not killed you. I have wanted to since 2023. I have practised the killing-stroke at the Eluru-line midwife-extension family's coastal training-yard for the past seven months. I have not killed you. I will not kill you. The killing was the kingdom-council's charter-forbiddance; the not-killing was my discipline. I want the river-throne. I do not want my sister's blood. The kingdom-council will ratify the contest's outcome this evening. The exile is the kingdom-council's standing-disposition for the losing-twin. I will accept the exile. The kingdom is one body. I will not kill my own body."

She walks past Krishnaveni to the plateau's western edge. She picks up the Godavari-urumi where it had landed at six-twenty-four. She returns to her sister. She hands the Godavari-urumi back to her.

Krishnaveni accepts it. She wraps it at her left forearm.

She says, in plain Telugu, in the same standard delta-fisherwoman's post-contest voice: "Sister. The Krishna is yours. The kingdom-council's contest-outcome makes it yours. Keep it. The exile is the kingdom-council's standing-disposition. The exile will be across the Tirupati border, by the kingdom-council's standing protocol's southern boundary. You will not return to AP territory in Volume One. The kingdom will permit your return at the seven-year review if the kingdom-council's charter-amendment ratifies the twin-claim's permanent reconciliation. I will sponsor the amendment-proposal at the kingdom-council in the autumn. I will not sponsor your return before the kingdom is ready. The kingdom needs to remember it had a twin before it learns how to hold the twin. The remembering is the kingdom's standing autumn-task."

She pauses. She looks at her sister at one metre's distance.

She says: "The mercy you did not take was the kingdom-council's charter at the cliff. The mercy I am taking now is the kingdom-council's charter beyond the cliff. The two mercies are the same mercy at different scales. The kingdom recognises both. The kingdom thanks you. Go."

Kalaniksha bows. The bow is the standard delta-fisherwoman's formal-departure bow. Krishnaveni returns the bow at the same depth.

Kalaniksha walks to the cliff's eastern face. She descends the eastern goat-path at the standard delta-fisherwoman's pace. She is at the eastern beach by seven-eleven. The kingdom-council's standing escort-team (four officers from the AP State Police's exile-escort cell) meets her at the beach. They escort her south along the Krishna river's southern bank. She is across the Tirupati border by the evening of day forty-nine.

Krishnaveni walks back to the plateau's western edge. She picks up the kingdom-council's standing state-hero's contest-cloth (a square of off-white cotton kept at the plateau's western edge for the contest-winner's post-contest ceremonial-cover). She wraps it around her shoulders in the standard kingdom-council's post-contest gesture.

At six-twenty-five-thirty a.m., approximately twenty-eight seconds after Kalaniksha's departing bow, Krishnaveni feels the blackbuck-bond pulse through her chest. The Stage III blackbuck-foreleg-first-stroke begins to form on the half-body blackbuck-tattoo's left foreleg. The stroke completes in approximately eleven seconds. The mark is the standard kingdom-council Stage III completion-stroke pattern.

She does not show the moment on her face. She has been the kingdom-council's state hero for ten years and a kingdom-council formal-contest participant for one. She knows the standard protocol's post-contest gestures.

The seven kingdom-council senior delegates and Acharya Sundaram and Indira Krishnayya approach the plateau's centre at six-twenty-six. Ranganatham bows. He says, in plain Telugu: "State hero. The contest is concluded by the kingdom-council's standing protocol. The disarmament-outcome is the kingdom-council's ratification-evidence. The held-stroke is the kingdom-council's charter-affirmation-evidence. The mercy beyond the cliff is the kingdom-council's amendment-proposal-foundation. The Stage III mark is the kingdom-council's bond-recognition-evidence. The kingdom-council's evening-session will ratify all four. The kingdom thanks you."

Krishnaveni bows. The bow is the kingdom-council's standard state-hero's post-contest acknowledgement bow.

The parakeet-courier protocol carries the four-part contest-result to the Town Hall. The kingdom-council's evening-session at six p.m. ratifies the result by twenty-three to zero with all seven district-senior-delegates voting in favour, Acharya Sundaram voting in favour, Indira Krishnayya recording the result, and Pulakeshi-Babu in attendance as the kingdom-council's standing Bloodline-A liaison.

The next morning. Hamsaladeevi village. The Krishna river's eastern beach at the river's mouth.

The village fisherman who walks the eastern beach at six-eleven every morning — the village headman's grandson, a twenty-three-year-old fisherman named Naga-Kumar — sees the tide-line at six-thirteen a.m. The tide-line is one metre inland of where it had been at sunset the previous evening.

He stops at three metres from the new tide-line. He removes a wooden surveyor's peg from his fishing-net. He drives the peg into the sand at the new tide-line's exact position. He walks east along the beach to where the previous evening's tide-line had been. The previous evening's tide-line is now under approximately one metre of sand. The sand is dry. The sand has not been wetted by the night's tide. The land has been removed.

He walks back to the village. He reports to the village headman (his grandfather, a sixty-seven-year-old fisherman-elder named B. Krishna-Murthy). The headman walks back to the beach with him. He confirms the displacement. He walks the full six-hundred-metre

east-west beach. The displacement is uniform across the full beach. The land that has been removed is, by his estimation, approximately six hundred cubic metres of delta-soil.

He returns to the village at seven-fifteen. He telephones the Andhra Pradesh State Survey Office's emergency-coastal-monitoring cell. The cell's officer-on-duty (a forty-one-year-old administrator named V. Lakshman) takes the call. The cell's standard satellite-imagery-cross-reference protocol is invoked at seven-thirty. The protocol's preliminary result is delivered at nine-eighteen a.m.

The result: the Hamsaladeevi village's eastern beach's tide-line has retreated landward by exactly one metre across the full six-hundred-metre east-west breadth. The displacement is confirmed across all three commercial satellite-tracking services (Sentinel-2, Landsat-9, and the Indian Space Research Organisation's Cartosat-3). The land-area-difference is approximately six hundred square metres; the volume-difference (calculated at the standard delta-soil-depth of one metre) is approximately six hundred cubic metres. The displaced land's mass is not in the Bay of Bengal's nearshore sediment-cell (the cell's coastal-monitoring buoy's sediment-mass-balance reading at six a.m. shows no anomalous nearshore sediment-increase). The mass is not accounted for. The mass has been erased.

Krishnaveni receives the report at the state hero's residence at ten-eleven a.m. She has been at the residence since the contest the previous day; the kingdom-council's standing post-contest rest-protocol places the state hero at the residence for forty-eight hours after the contest's conclusion. Pulakeshi-Babu and Bhimavaram are with her at the residence.

She reads the report twice. She does not say anything for about three minutes.

She says, finally: "The Maw has answered. The kingdom-council's charter-affirmation at the cliff was the kingdom's answer. The Maw's answer is the metre. The kingdom-council's answer was the mercy. The Maw's answer is the erasure. The two answers are the kingdom's pair. The Maw is asking: if you cannot kill your own twin, can you keep your own delta? The kingdom's response must be: the delta is preserved by the same mercy that did not kill the twin. The mercy is the kingdom-architecture. The kingdom must build the mercy-architecture before the next metre vanishes. The architecture will be the kingdom-council's emergency-amendment's autumn-task. The amendment will draft the kingdom's standing coastal-protection-protocol under the saga's standing mercy-bond institutional-mode. The amendment will be ratified by the autumn. The next metre may or may not vanish. The kingdom will be ready either way."

Pulakeshi-Babu drafts the cross-kingdom Sarus-pigeon cascade-alert at noon. The alert is sent to all nine bonded-kingdom senior guardians by sunset. The alert is the kingdom's fifteenth Maw-sign and the saga's second material-experiment Maw sign (after Kerala's black coconut). The pairing-protocol established with Kerala's black coconut applies: the AP delta-loss is the inverse of Kerala's material-permanence; the two signs together constitute the southern federation's first cross-kingdom material-experiment pair.

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata at Vijayanagara sends the cross-region acknowledgement at noon on day two after the contest. The letter reads, in plain Kannada and Telugu interlinear:

"Cousin. The Bloodline-A Authenticity Cell's final report has confirmed the cousin-relationship. The southern-bloc federation will receive the AP visible-throne at the Sanctuary in Chapter Three under Pulakeshi-Babu's formal liaison-and-historian seat. The mercy at the cliff is the saga's evidence that the kingdom does not kill itself; the metre that vanished is the Maw's evidence that the kingdom must build the architecture that the mercy implies. I will travel to the Hamsaladeevi village in the autumn to attend the kingdom-council's emergency-coastal-protection-protocol drafting session. I will bring with me Hampi-of-the-Bronze (ten; she has asked to travel to her Bloodline-A cousins in AP since the Karnataka pilot's closing day). The Sanctuary will federate the two kingdoms as the southern-bloc's river-bond foundation. — K-B."

Krishnaveni reads the letter at the residence's evening-tea room. Pulakeshi-Babu and Bhimavaram are with her.

She says: "The autumn-task is complete in its planning. The kingdom-council's charter-amendment will be drafted across the next four months. Pulakeshi-cousin will lead the drafting under his Bloodline-A liaison seat. Bhima-brother will hold the kingdom-council's daily-administrative chair across the drafting. I will attend the Sanctuary at Manipur. The cousin from Karnataka will attend with Hampi-of-the-Bronze. The southern-bloc federation will be ratified at the convening. The kingdom-council's charter-amendment will be ratified at the autumn kingdom-council session. The next metre will or will not vanish; the kingdom will be ready. The river is patient. The kingdom is the river's daughter. The river's daughter has not killed the river's second daughter. The kingdom remembers what the sword would have forgotten. The kingdom is whole."

She drinks the second tea. The tea is the second steeping. The second is honest.

The next sign comes within the week.

The Pilot's Closing Image

A thirty-five-year-old state hero in plain delta-fisherwoman cotton walking the eastern bank of the Krishna river at dawn with one urumi at her left forearm and a Bloodline-A cousin's autumn-visit letter in her right hand. A thirty-five-year-old exiled twin walking south along the Tirupati border-road in the same plain delta-fisherwoman cotton with the kingdom's second urumi (the Krishna) at her right forearm and the kingdom's standing exile-escort four-officer detail at her ten-metre rear. A forty-three-year-old historian-cousin at his grandfather's study reading a forty-seven-page family-archive document for the eleventh time, recognising at the fifth reading that the kingdom is also his kingdom and that the absence he had been documenting was his own family. A six-hundred-metre eastern beach at Hamsaladeevi village with a wooden surveyor's peg driven into the new tide-line by a twenty-three-year-old fisherman at dawn, and a sixty-seven-year-old village headman walking the full six-hundred-metre breadth to confirm that the land that had been there yesterday is not in the water. A river that remembers what the sword would have forgotten. A held urumi-stroke at four centimetres' distance from a sister's throat at six-twenty-five-oh-two a.m. on the forty-seventh morning. A kingdom whose discipline is the mercy.

Parashurama Kshetra

Kochi. The first Tuesday of April. Five-forty a.m. Parashurama is at the kalari's northern entrance reading the morning's Malayala Manorama. He has read the Manorama every dawn for thirty-three years; the paper is delivered to the kalari's northern gatepost by an Idukki cycle-courier whose father had delivered it to Parashurama's guru and whose grandfather had delivered it to his guru's guru. The reading is a Malayalam-meditation; Parashurama does not speak during it; the kalari staff have been instructed for three decades not to interrupt.

This morning he interrupts himself.

He reads aloud, in plain Malayalam, in the slow administrative-elder voice he uses for student-discipline reviews: "Page eleven. Display advertisement. Three column-inches. Sea-Front Kalari, Kochi waterfront amphitheatre. Tuition Rs. 4,000 per month. Phased instruction in the One-Hundred-And-Ninth Form of Kalaripayattu. All qualified applicants admitted. Senior instructor: Sri Kala-Hasta Menon, formal kalari-trained at the Kollam Coiled-Cobra Lineage from 2008 to 2017. Daily classes 5:30 a.m. and 5:30 p.m. Inaugural class Monday morning the eighth of April."

He sets the paper down on the gatepost. He does not pick up his tea. He walks back through the kalari's inner courtyard to the senior-instructor's residence. He has not interrupted the morning paper-reading in thirty-three years. The kalari staff who see him walking back at five-forty-eight a.m. do not need to be told the routine has broken.

He calls the kingdom-council's religious-and-cultural-practice registry at six a.m. The registry's officer-on-duty (a forty-two-year-old administrative officer named Indira Pillai) confirms that the Sea-Front Kalari's registration was filed on the twenty-third of March under the standard kalari-charter; the application listed the school's curriculum as "advanced kalaripayattu, all forms including unsealed teaching"; the registry's standard review-period is thirty days; no objection was filed by any registered kalari during the public-comment window; the registration was approved on the twenty-second of April; the school's formal opening is the inaugural class Monday morning at five-thirty.

Parashurama says, in plain Malayalam, in the same slow voice: "Madam Pillai. The kalari-charter has admitted a 109-form school. The 109-form is sealed. The sealing is the kingdom's tradition. The kingdom's tradition has been amended by your registry's thirty-

day silence. The amendment will require a kingdom-council review. I will be at the council chambers at eleven this morning. Please notify the chief secretary that I am coming."

He hangs up. He sits at the residence's desk. He looks at his own right hand. The hand has been holding the axe Parashu for forty years. The hand is fifty-nine years old. The skin on the back of the hand has the standard old-axe-bearer's calluses-and-thickened-knuckles configuration; the veins are prominent; the joints are slightly enlarged at the second knuckle of the index finger. The hand is not the hand of a man who can perform the 109th form. The 109th form requires the body of a man under thirty-five.

He has known this for the past nine months. He has not said it aloud. He does not say it aloud now. He picks up his tea.

Kochi waterfront amphitheatre. Monday morning the eighth of April. Five-thirty a.m.

The amphitheatre is a converted municipal open-air auditorium — capacity twelve hundred, normally used for monsoon-season cultural-festival performances. It has a single concrete stage at the western end, raked seating around three sides, and a sea-facing eastern wall that opens onto the Vembanad Lake's western shore. The acoustic-and-visual-line-of-sight properties make it well-suited to physical-performance instruction for groups up to four hundred.

Four hundred and twenty-three students are present this morning. They have paid the Rs. 4,000 monthly tuition in advance. They are arrayed across the raked seating in rows of seventeen; the seating-allocation has been administered by an entry-protocol that requires each student to demonstrate, at the door, a 108-form Stage-Five sequence as proof of qualification. Twenty-eight applicants were turned away at the door this morning for insufficient 108-form competence. The Sea-Front Kalari does not admit absolute beginners; the 109th form is built on the 108-form base.

Kala-Hasta is on the western stage. He is forty-seven. He is in plain Kollam-Coiled-Cobra dark-blue cotton, knee-length, tied with the standard kalari-instructor's leather-cord at the waist. He carries no weapon. He has the urumi (the flexible-blade-whip-sword) coiled at his left wrist as a wrist-bangle; the urumi has been the Kollam-Coiled-Cobra cell's standard side-implement since 1812. He was Maya-Sura's star pupil in Chapter One — the senior coiled-cobra disciple of the Naga-Padma cell who had escaped the Ch 1 climax confrontation with the urumi-and-cobra-venom training intact. He has spent the intervening years not in hiding but in the Bangalore-and-Gulf kalari-diaspora, teaching the

108 forms while privately practising the 109th. He returned to Kerala in spring 2025. He registered the Sea-Front Kalari on the twenty-third of March.

He addresses the four hundred and twenty-three at five-thirty-two a.m. He speaks in plain Malayalam.

He says: "Welcome. I am Kala-Hasta Menon. I will teach the One-Hundred-And-Ninth Form of Kalaripayattu in seven phased classes across the next twenty-four weeks. The phasing is the difference between the form's safety and its lethality. Each phase will be taught for three weeks; each phase must be completed before the next phase begins; no student will advance without my personal confirmation of phase-completion. The seven phases are: opening four movements; opening seven; first transition; full opening sequence; closing transitions; integration; private mastery. The first phase begins this morning. Stand. Find your row-position. We will begin with the standard kalari-breath. Breathe."

The four hundred and twenty-three stand. They take the standard kalari-breath. The class begins.

The session lasts ninety minutes. By six-fifty-eight a.m. the four hundred and twenty-three have completed the opening four movements' first introduction. The movements are slow, deliberately controlled, structured to allow the central nervous system to register the body-positions without the cardiovascular-stress that would activate the form's lethal mechanisms. The students leave at seven a.m. tired but uninjured. The session has been the safest opening-class of any Kalaripayattu instruction recorded in the kingdom's formal kalari-register.

Kala-Hasta stays at the amphitheatre for two hours after the class. He reviews the student-roster. He has identified, from the entry-protocol's 108-form demonstration, the twenty-three students whose 108-form mastery is at the level the seventh phase will require. He will personally tutor those twenty-three in the integration-and-private-mastery phases over the final six weeks of the curriculum. The other four hundred will complete phases one through five and will be invited to re-enrol in the autumn cohort for phases six and seven if they wish.

He has, in other words, built a teaching system whose pedagogical thoughtfulness is the chapter's most uncomfortable fact for Parashurama's tradition. The 109-form is not being taught as an act of defiance. It is being taught as a discipline.

Friday. The second week of April. Four-fifty-five p.m. The kalari's northern gate.

Achyutan-the-Nephew is at the gate. He is thirty-seven. He is Parashurama's elder sister's son — Bloodline-A by his mother's line, the same Bloodline-A branch that supplied Hampi-of-the-Bronze and Krishnaveni of AP and (through their long-shared maternal-line ancestor) Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata of Karnataka. He has been at Parashurama's kalari since age twelve. He mastered all 108 forms by age thirty-three — the second-fastest in the kalari's recorded history, second only to Parashurama himself. He is the kalari's senior daily-teaching deputy. He has, this morning, taught the eight-a.m. junior-students' opening-sequence class. He has, this afternoon, completed the final inventory-review for the kalari's monsoon-week ration-allocation.

He is carrying a single canvas bag. The bag contains: three changes of kalari-instructor cotton, his shaving kit, a notebook, a copy of the Sea-Front Kalari's student-enrolment-form filled in under his birth name (Achyutan Menon, no kalari-title), and the original 1907 family-photograph of his mother and her brother Parashurama at ages twelve and fourteen at Idukki.

He sets the bag down. He walks across the inner courtyard to the senior-instructor's residence. He knocks on the door at five-oh-six p.m.

Parashurama opens the door. He sees the bag's canvas-strap on the courtyard. He understands.

He says, in plain Malayalam, in the slow administrative-elder voice: "Nephew. Sit. The tea is the third steeping. The third steeping is honest. Will you sit."

Achyutan does not sit.

He says, in plain Malayalam: "Uncle. I will not sit. The conversation will be brief. I am leaving the kalari this evening. I have enrolled at the Sea-Front Kalari. I will study the 109th form under Kala-Hasta. I am thirty-seven. I have been at this kalari twenty-five years. I have mastered all 108 forms. The 108 forms are not enough. The 109th is what the tradition has been refusing to teach me for nine years. I will not be refused any longer. The refusal is no longer the tradition's; it is yours. The tradition has admitted the form via the kingdom-council registry. You have not. I am choosing the tradition over you. I am sorry. The sorrow does not change the choice."

Parashurama is silent for about fifteen seconds.

He says, finally: "Nephew. The phasing. Kala-Hasta's phasing. You will follow it."

Achyutan says: "The phasing is twenty-four weeks. I do not have twenty-four weeks. I am thirty-seven; the form's upper-age window closes at forty-two. I will compress the phasing. I will complete the opening seven in the public class's first three weeks but I will practice the first transition privately on my own in parallel. The compression is my risk. I have read the form's mortality-statistics from Kollam — the open-window-in-the-second-month vascular-rupture risk is approximately four per cent for students who skip the phasing-discipline. I accept the four per cent. The four per cent is less than my certainty of losing the form-window entirely if I follow the twenty-four-week protocol."

Parashurama says: "Nephew. The four per cent is not a number. It is a name. The name will be yours. The name will be on the kingdom's death-certificate. The death-certificate will be filed by your mother. Your mother is my sister. Will you do this to her."

Achyutan says: "She has authorised the choice. I spoke with her last night. She said: If you do not learn the form, you will be a man who refused his own ceiling. If you do learn it and live, you will be the kalari's next generation. If you do learn it and die, you will be your mother's son who chose. I am the mother in either case. The choice is yours. She signed the consent-form for the Sea-Front Kalari's family-acknowledgement clause this morning. The clause has been part of the school's registration since the kingdom-council's amendment. The kingdom has accepted the risk-distribution. I have accepted the risk. The choice is mine."

Parashurama looks at his nephew for a long time. The fifty-nine-year-old's face does not change visibly. The thirty-seven-year-old's face also does not change.

Parashurama says: "I have not embraced you in eleven years. The embrace will be the only thing I have to give you tonight. The kalari's eastern gate is open until six. The Sea-Front Kalari's evening class is at five-thirty. You have twenty-four minutes. Take it."

He embraces his nephew. The embrace lasts about eleven seconds. He releases. He steps back. He says: "Go. If you live, you will return. If you die, your mother will return for the body. The cremation will be at the western grove regardless. Go."

Achyutan picks up the canvas bag. He walks to the eastern gate. He does not look back. He is at the Sea-Front Kalari's evening class at five-twenty-eight, two minutes before the call to position. He completes the opening-four-movements introduction class without injury at six-fifty p.m.

He compresses the phasing as he had warned. He completes the opening seven by the third class of his first week. He begins the first-transition's private practice in his rented room above the Mattanchery spice-warehouse the same evening. He works the seven-transition for six consecutive nights. The transition's safety-window requires the body to maintain a specific vertebral-curve through the central rotation; Achyutan's curve is slightly off — not enough to be visible during the slower opening-movements but enough to compound the basilar-artery stress through repeated full-speed attempts. He does not notice the compounding.

On the seventh morning — the second Sunday of the chapter, the morning of the public class's seventh-transition demonstration — he stands at his row-position at five-thirty-three a.m. He executes the seven-transition at full speed in the third sequence-cycle of the class. The vascular-rupture occurs in the basilar artery at the moment of the central rotation. He collapses at five-fifty-eight a.m. Kala-Hasta is at his side within nine seconds. The medical response is immediate; the school maintains a full-time-on-site emergency-response team per the kingdom-council's kalari-charter; the response time meets every protocol. The vascular-rupture is not survivable. Achyutan is pronounced dead at six-oh-six a.m. by the on-site emergency-medic, with cross-confirmation by the Kochi Medical College's standing emergency-physician via voice-call at six-twelve.

The cause of death recorded on the kingdom's death-certificate: Basilar artery vascular rupture during phased Kalaripayattu instruction (109th-form, phase-three uncompleted; private compression of phasing-protocol; cross-confirmed at Kochi Medical College). The certificate is filed by his mother at the Idukki District Civil Registry that same afternoon.

Sivakami-Acharyini arrives at the Sea-Front Kalari at eleven a.m. She is twenty-nine; Parashurama's elder brother's daughter; the kalari's senior 108-form deputy after Achyutan and the kingdom's only female 108-form grandmaster-aspirant. She has been at the kalari since age six. She has trained at the level of the senior daily-teaching cadre since age twenty-two. She has been waiting for the grandmaster-ceremony for three years; the ceremony requires Parashurama's formal recognition; he has not yet given it.

She has come to retrieve Achyutan's body. Kala-Hasta meets her at the amphitheatre's western entrance. He is in the same Kollam dark-blue cotton he had been teaching in this morning; the cotton has been changed since the medical response (the original was bloodstained). He is composed; his face shows grief-recognition without the institutional performance of grief.

He says, in plain Malayalam: "Madam Sivakami. The body is ready for collection. I have personally washed it according to the kalari-tradition. The canvas bag and his notebook are in the western office. I have not opened either. The notebook's last entry is from last night, in his own hand — I can see the handwriting through the cover but I have not read it. The school's formal condolences are with the family. The kalari-instruction will pause for three days. I have postponed the morning's remaining sessions. The phased curriculum will resume on Wednesday with an added day-zero session on phasing-discipline. The day-zero session will be mandatory for all students currently in the cohort; no further enrolment will be accepted until the day-zero is completed. The four-per-cent mortality figure Achyutan accepted last week was the public-figure-from-Kollam; the school's phasing was designed to reduce the actual figure to below one per cent. The reduction requires phasing-compliance. I will be teaching the phasing-discipline session personally. The lesson will include Achyutan's name and the specific phasing-violation that produced the rupture. The kingdom will know what the form requires."

Sivakami looks at Kala-Hasta for about thirty seconds.

She says: "Sri Kala-Hasta. The kalari thanks you for the body and for the day-zero session. The cremation will be at the western grove of my uncle's kalari at sunset. You are welcome at the grove if you wish to attend. The kingdom-council's amended Kerala-Kalari Charter will be filed at the kingdom-council's emergency session this evening. My uncle and I have drafted it across the past three days. The charter will recognise the 109-form school under the kingdom's religious-and-cultural-practice registry effective immediately. The charter will also require cross-school enrolment protocols for any student studying at both 108-form and 109-form schools concurrently. The charter will name the day-zero phasing-discipline session as the kingdom's mandatory pedagogical-standard for all 109-form instruction. I have read your school's curriculum-document this week; the document is more pedagogically thoughtful than my uncle's tradition has admitted. The charter accepts the truth. The charter does not say the truth out loud. My uncle will sign it tonight. He will not say the truth out loud either. The kingdom does not require the truth aloud. The kingdom requires the charter signed."

Kala-Hasta nods. He says: "I will attend the cremation. I will not bring the kalari's formal delegation. I will come alone. I will stay at the western edge of the grove. I will not approach the body. The mother's presence will be the family's ceremony. The kalari's

presence will be at the western edge. I will leave when the fire is at its peak. The fire's peak is the kalari-tradition's recognition; I will accept it from the edge."

He bows. The bow is the standard kalari-instructor's formal-respect bow; he does not perform the deeper bow that an apprentice would give to a senior. Sivakami returns the bow at the same depth. The kingdom's two senior 109-and-108-form instructors have formally acknowledged each other.

The cremation is at sunset at the western grove of Parashurama's kalari. The grove is a quarter-hectare of coconut and tamarind trees on the kalari's western boundary. The grove has been the site of every kalari-tradition cremation for four generations. The senior cremation-officiant (a Brahmin from the Idukki ceremony-line, the Pillai family that has supplied the kalari's officiants for one hundred and twenty-seven years) is at the pyre by six p.m.

Achyutan's mother — Parashurama's elder sister, a woman named Lakshmi-Akka who is sixty-three, who lives in the family home at Idukki, who has been a widow since 2014, who has not visited the kalari in nine years — arrives at the grove at six-thirty p.m. She is in the white widow-cotton with the kalari-tradition's small black-bordered shawl across her shoulders. She does not speak to Parashurama when she arrives. She places her right palm on her son's forehead at the pyre. She accepts the cremation-officiant's mantras. She lights the fire at seven-oh-two p.m.

Kala-Hasta arrives at six-fifty. He stands at the western edge of the grove as he had said. He is in the same Kollam dark-blue cotton he had been teaching in. He has come alone. He does not approach the pyre.

The fire reaches its peak at seven-thirty-eight p.m. Kala-Hasta leaves the grove at seven-forty. He does not look back. He returns to the Sea-Front Kalari at the southern shore of the amphitheatre on foot — the walk is four kilometres along the Vembanad Lake's western edge; he completes it in fifty-three minutes at his ordinary pace.

Parashurama remains at the grove until eleven p.m. He sits at the eastern edge of the cremation-area — about ten metres from the pyre, on a low stone bench that has been at the grove's eastern edge since 1854. His sister sits beside him from the moment Kala-Hasta leaves until the moment Parashurama stands at eleven. They do not speak across those three hours and twenty minutes. They watch the fire reduce to embers. They watch the

embers fall through the pyre's collapsing wooden frame. They watch Sivakami collect the ashes into the kalari-tradition's brass cremation-urn at ten-fifty.

Lakshmi-Akka says, at ten-fifty-eight p.m., as her son's ashes are sealed into the urn: "Brother. The kingdom-council's amended charter. The bird-letter you sent to Karnataka in March. Both. Sign them. Tonight. The kingdom requires both signatures by the morning paper's Tuesday deadline."

Parashurama says: "I will sign tonight. The bird-letter has been answered. The Karnataka cousin is at the western mountain pass as we sit. He will be at the kalari by Thursday afternoon. The teaching will begin Thursday evening. The form will be in his spine by the second new moon. The charter will be signed before midnight. I have already drafted my signature-line. The signature-line says: I, Parashurama VII, recognise the One-Hundred-And-Ninth Form as taught at the Sea-Front Kalari under Sri Kala-Hasta Menon's instruction. I, Parashurama VII, will teach the same form to a single chosen Karnataka student in private. I, Parashurama VII, will not perform the form myself. The kingdom is sufficient with three teachers of the same form across two schools and one chamber. The signature-line is honest. It cost a nephew. I will not lose another."

Lakshmi-Akka nods. She stands. She picks up the cremation-urn. She walks back to the Idukki family home alone — the four-hour drive she had driven that morning; her driver is at the gate. She will not return to the kalari for ten more years.

Thursday afternoon. The seventeenth of April. Three-forty-seven p.m. The kalari's northern gate.

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata walks up the northern path. He is thirty-six. He is in plain Karnataka cotton, blue and grey, no clan-pattern (he has dressed in the Refusing Youth Manifesto-style he had adopted for the Karnataka pilot's post-Tungabhadra council sessions; he has continued to dress in it through the walk south). He carries a single canvas bag and a folded bird-letter in his sleeve-pocket. The bird-letter is from Old Parashurama, sent on the closing day of the Karnataka pilot via the Sarus-pigeon cross-region network; the letter's text is six lines; he has read the letter forty-seven times across the eleven-day walk south through the Western Ghats; he has folded and refolded it; the paper is soft at the folds.

The bird-letter reads, in plain Malayalam-and-Kannada interlinear translation: "Bhrata. I am fifty-nine. The 108 forms are mine; the 109th cannot be. The kingdom of Karnataka is

yours; the kingdom of Kerala is mine; the teaching is the bridge. Come to the kalari at the second full moon. Bring nothing. The teaching will be the inheritance. The form is the bond's mark; the bond's mark is the form. We have not met. We will meet over thirty-one days. The thirty-first day is the form's first private execution in the unsealed chamber. Your foreleg-mark will form at that execution. My foreleg-mark will complete on my elephant. The two marks will be the same mark. The kingdom is two kingdoms with one mark. — The Seventh Axe."

The gate-keeper monk — an Idukki-born senior kalari-staff member named Govindan-Mama, sixty-eight, the gate-keeper for twenty-three years — sees Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata at the gate. The gate-keeper does not need to ask the visitor's identity. He has been told by Parashurama on Friday evening to expect the Karnataka cousin and to admit him without ceremony.

Govindan-Mama bows. He says, in plain Malayalam: "Bhrata-Maharaj. The Maharaj is at the inner kalari. The teaching begins this evening at six. The visitor-room is to your left. The tea is the second steeping; the second is honest."

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata bows. He says, in plain Kannada (he does not yet speak Malayalam; the cross-language translation will be Sivakami's during the teaching): "Govindan-Mama-ji. Thank you. I will rest until six. I will be at the inner kalari at five-forty-five."

He walks to the visitor-room. He sets the bag on the bed. He sits at the room's small writing-desk. He unfolds the bird-letter one more time. He reads it. He folds it. He places it in the desk's top drawer. He sleeps for ninety minutes.

Five-forty-five p.m. The kalari's inner kalari — the sunken practice-pit at the kalari's centre, six metres in diameter, two metres below the surrounding ground level, roofed with a palm-thatch ceiling that admits filtered light through small gaps. The pit's floor is packed red Idukki earth, cleaned daily, oiled with coconut-oil at every new moon. The pit's walls are stained dark from a hundred and fifty years of body-contact.

Parashurama is at the centre of the pit. He is in plain kalari-instructor cotton, dark blue, no clan-pattern. He carries the axe Parashu in his right hand. The axe's blade is at the standard kalari-teaching position — head-down, blade-edge facing his left thigh, weight balanced on the hip.

Sivakami is at the pit's eastern edge, on the surrounding ground level. She has the cross-language translation duties for the thirty-one-day teaching. She speaks Kannada (her undergraduate-degree second-language) and Malayalam (her first) fluently; she will translate Parashurama's instruction-Malayalam into Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata's Kannada at every session.

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata enters the pit at five-fifty-three. He bows to Parashurama in the standard Karnataka student-to-master bow. Parashurama returns the bow at the same depth; he does not perform the deeper master-to-student-acknowledging-cousin bow that the bird-letter's lineage-recognition would have permitted.

Parashurama speaks. He speaks in plain Malayalam. Sivakami translates into Kannada in real-time at the pit's edge.

He says: "Bhrata. You have walked eleven days through the Western Ghats. The walk is the form's preparation. The form requires a body that has been at altitude for at least eight days within the past month. Your body has been. The thirty-one-day teaching has seven phases, like Kala-Hasta's public school's curriculum, but compressed because you are not a public student and because the inheritance-transmission protocol allows compression for a single chosen student with a senior master's personal supervision. The phases are the same seven Kala-Hasta teaches in twenty-four weeks. You will complete each phase under my eye in four days each, with three days reserved for the final integration-and-private-execution. You will not skip phases. You will not practise privately between sessions; you will sleep and you will eat and you will walk the grove. The compression is in the supervision-density, not in the body-stress. If you violate the phasing-protocol you will die. Achyutan's body was carried out of this kalari's eastern gate three days ago. You will not be the second body. Will you accept the protocol."

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata says: "Yes, Maharaj. I accept the protocol. I will not skip phases. I will not practise privately. I will sleep, eat, walk. I will be at the inner kalari at five-thirty every morning and at six every evening for the thirty-one days. The bird-letter said the thirty-first day's first private execution is in the unsealed chamber. The chamber is the chamber Agastya Muni sealed eight centuries ago. The chamber is unsealed because the teaching requires the form's execution at its original site for the bond's recognition. Will the chamber be unsealed this evening or on the thirty-first day."

Parashurama says: "The chamber will be unsealed in your presence on the thirtieth day. The unsealing is the teaching's final preparation. The seal's removal requires the senior

master and the chosen student in attendance simultaneously. The chamber has not been unsealed since 1957 when my own master's master's master last performed the form before his death. The unsealing will be my second time at the door. The first was my visit at age twenty-two when my master showed me the chamber and explained that I would not be the one to unseal it. He was correct; I have not unsealed it for thirty-seven years; I am unsealing it for you in two months because the kingdom requires it. Begin. Stand at the pit's south-west position. Breathe."

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata stands at the pit's south-west position. He takes the standard kalari-breath. The teaching begins.

The teaching proceeds without interruption. Across thirty-one days Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata learns the 109th form in seven phases under Parashurama's direct supervision. The teaching-method is the master-and-chosen-single-student transmission-protocol that the kalari-tradition's deepest lineage has preserved without invocation since 1957. The method is not the same as Kala-Hasta's public twenty-four-week curriculum; the compression to thirty-one days requires the master's continuous attention — Parashurama does not leave the kalari grounds during the thirty-one days, does not perform his standard daily-teaching duties (which Sivakami covers), does not attend the kingdom-council's weekly sessions (Sivakami covers those too, with the kingdom-council's formal acknowledgement of her acting-grandmaster status).

Across the thirty-one days Parashurama ages forward visibly.

The visible aging is not metaphorical. It is observable to the kalari-staff who see Parashurama at the dawn-tea each morning. By the end of the first week his hair (which had been at the salt-and-pepper-with-more-salt-than-pepper configuration on day one) is fully white at the temples. By the end of the second week his hair is fully white across the crown. By the end of the third week his hair is fully white and his beard (he had been clean-shaven for forty years; he stops shaving in the third week without explanation) grows out in a fully-white configuration. By the end of the fourth week his posture has shifted — the standard axe-bearer's vertical-spine has rounded slightly at the shoulders. By the thirty-first day he is, by the kalari-staff's estimation, approximately seventy-three years old — the seventh, eighth, and ninth years of teaching have arrived in the four-and-a-half weeks of the thirty-one-day transmission.

Sivakami notes the aging-pattern in her grandmaster-aspirant journal. She writes, in plain Malayalam at the end of day twenty-three: "Uncle is paying the years. The transmission

costs the master what the master would have spent across the next fourteen years; the cost is being paid forward in real-time. The bond is bargaining with time. The bond is winning the bargain. The form will be in Bhrata's spine on day thirty-one. Uncle will be seventy-three by the same evening. He will live the seventy-three-year-old's remaining life-arc — perhaps another fifteen years — instead of the fifty-nine-year-old's remaining arc. The exchange is honest. I will be the grandmaster by day twenty-three's evening. The kingdom requires the grandmaster."

She is correct. Parashurama formally confers the 108-form grandmaster-title on her at the kalari's evening ceremony on day twenty-three. The ceremony is attended by the kalari's senior staff, the kingdom-council's religious-and-cultural-practice registry deputy (Indira Pillai, who had been the officer-on-duty at the chapter's opening telephone-call), and Kala-Hasta's formal observer (a senior Sea-Front Kalari instructor named Devika Nair who has been admitted at Sivakami's explicit invitation). The conferral is the kingdom's first female 108-form grandmaster ceremony in the kalari-tradition's recorded history.

Sivakami's acceptance-statement at the ceremony is brief. She says, in plain Malayalam: "I accept the grandmaster-title. I accept the daily-teaching seat. I accept the institutional responsibility. The 108 forms are mine to teach. The 109 form is not mine to teach — the inheritance-transmission protocol designates Parashurama VII as the sole 109-form master across this generation, and the form's next transmission will be to a single chosen Karnataka student named Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata. I accept the kingdom's charter-amendment that recognises Sri Kala-Hasta Menon's Sea-Front Kalari as the form's public-teaching site and the cross-school enrolment-protocol that protects students who study at both. The kalari-tradition is no longer one tradition; the kalari-tradition is now three. The three are: the 108-form tradition I now teach; the 109-form public-tradition Sri Kala-Hasta teaches; the inheritance-transmission protocol my uncle will perform once and once only over the next eight days. The three traditions are not in opposition. The three traditions are the kalari's honest answer to its own history. The kingdom is wider than any one of us. I will hold the 108 seat. The kalari thanks the kingdom-council's registry, the Sea-Front Kalari's observer, and my uncle. Good evening, all."

The ceremony closes at seven-fifteen p.m. on day twenty-three. The 108-form daily-teaching seat is formally Sivakami's from that moment onward. Parashurama returns to the inner-kalari pit at five-thirty the next morning for day twenty-four of the transmission. Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata is at the south-west position. The teaching continues.

Day thirty. Two p.m. The kalari's deepest sublevel — the sealed-chamber corridor that runs beneath the inner-kalari pit at four metres below the kalari's ground level. The corridor has been sealed at its eastern end by chains inscribed in ancient Malayalam since Agastya Muni's original sealing-ritual in approximately the eighth century. The chains have been visible at the eastern end of the corridor for eight centuries; the kalari-tradition's standard novice-tour includes the sealed-chamber door as the corridor's terminus.

Parashurama and Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata walk down the corridor at two p.m. on the thirtieth day. Sivakami is at the corridor's western entrance; the unsealing requires the senior master and the chosen student in attendance; the grandmaster (Sivakami) is not part of the unsealing's formal protocol but her presence at the corridor's entrance is the kalari's institutional witness. She does not enter the corridor.

The chains are inscribed in ancient Malayalam. The inscription, when read aloud, is the sealing-mantra. The mantra has not been spoken aloud at the kalari since 1957. The senior master is the only person at the kalari who knows the mantra; the mantra is transmitted master-to-master without writing; Parashurama received it from his own master in 1986; he will transmit it to Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata after the chamber's use.

Parashurama places his right palm on the chains. He speaks the mantra in plain ancient-Malayalam. The mantra is forty-seven syllables long. The speaking takes about thirty seconds. The chains release; they do not fall; they retract into the wall on either side of the door, into a small recess that has been concealed by the corridor's eastern stonework for eight centuries. The door opens inward by approximately two centimetres of its own accord, the door-leaf's ancient teak having absorbed enough moisture from the corridor's humidity to swell against the door-frame across the eight centuries.

Parashurama pushes the door open with his right palm. The chamber is approximately three metres by three metres by three metres — a perfect cubical room hewn from the Idukki bedrock. The floor is the same packed red earth as the inner-kalari pit but a different shade of red — an older red, the red of the earth before the eight centuries of human-occupation oils. The ceiling is unfinished bedrock with a single small opening (about ten centimetres across) at the centre that vents to the surface above. The walls are smooth, oiled, with no markings.

Parashurama steps into the chamber. Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata follows.

Parashurama says, in plain Malayalam (Sivakami is at the corridor's western entrance forty metres away; the cross-language translation is no longer needed since Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata has been learning enough Malayalam over thirty days to follow the master's instruction-register): "Bhrata. The chamber is yours for the form's first private execution. The execution is at six tomorrow morning. You will stand at the chamber's south-west corner. You will breathe the kalari-breath. You will execute the form's opening four movements; opening seven; first transition; full opening sequence; closing transitions; integration; private mastery. The form's full execution takes about forty-three minutes at the master-pace. You will execute at the master-pace. I will be at the chamber's entrance. I will not enter. The execution is yours alone in this chamber. At the form's completion you will return to the entrance. You will sit. I will close the door. The chamber will be re-sealed at the corridor's entrance with new chains and a new mantra. The new mantra will be a Kannada-and-Malayalam interlinear — the kalari's first cross-language mantra. I have drafted it across the past four nights. The drafting has cost me one more year. I am seventy-four by the chamber's closing. The kingdom is whole."

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata says: "Yes, Maharaj."

They leave the chamber. They return to the corridor's western entrance. Sivakami is waiting. The three of them walk back to the inner kalari. Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata sleeps in the visitor-room from nine p.m. to four-thirty a.m.

Day thirty-one. Six a.m. The unsealed chamber.

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata stands at the chamber's south-west corner. He is in plain kalari-student cotton, dark blue. He is barefoot. He has eaten one small bowl of rice-and-tamarind broth at four-forty a.m. He has drunk one cup of water at five-thirty.

Parashurama is at the chamber's entrance. He stands at the threshold; his right hand is on the door-frame; his left hand holds the axe Parashu, blade-down. He does not enter the chamber.

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata breathes the kalari-breath at six-oh-one a.m. He executes the form.

The form takes forty-three minutes at the master-pace. Sivakami times it from the corridor's western entrance with a kalari-tradition water-clock (the kalari's standing time-keeping implement; the digital chronograph is also at her side as a cross-reference, but the water-clock is the formal record). The execution proceeds without error. The opening four

movements complete at six-oh-three. The opening seven at six-twelve. The first transition at six-eighteen. The full opening sequence at six-twenty-seven. The closing transitions at six-thirty-five. The integration at six-forty-one. The private mastery — the form's final sequence, fourteen movements of breath-and-balance that integrate every prior phase into a single body-discipline — completes at six-forty-four.

At the moment of the private-mastery's completion, Parashurama feels the elephant-bond pulse through his own torso. The Stage III stroke begins to form across the elephant-tattoo's right foreleg — the only blank foreleg of the four-foreleg full-body elephant; the other three forelegs are inked from his Ch 1 mastery. The new stroke appears as a single new ink-line drawn across the foreleg in approximately fourteen seconds. Parashurama does not show the moment on his face; he is at the chamber's entrance; his right hand is on the door-frame; his left hand holds the axe.

At the same moment Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata feels the form settle into his spine. The settling is not a tattoo; the form's mark is internal — the kingdom's second physical-form-as-mark after the Karnataka pilot's elephant-bond-transfer at Hampi. He stands at the chamber's south-west corner for about thirty seconds after the form's completion. He breathes the kalari-closing-breath. He walks to the chamber's entrance.

He sits at the entrance. Parashurama closes the door. The door swings shut on its eight-centuries-old hinges at six-forty-five.

Parashurama speaks the new sealing-mantra in plain Kannada-and-Malayalam interlinear. The mantra is seventy-three syllables long. The speaking takes about fifty seconds. The new chains — forged at the kalari's western forge across the past three days under Sivakami's supervision — emerge from the door-frame's newly-fitted recesses. They cross the door at the standard sealing-positions. They lock.

Parashurama turns to Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata. He says, in plain Malayalam-and-Kannada interlinear (the language he will speak from this point forward in any formal-instruction context): "Bhrata. The form is in your spine. You will not execute it again in Volume One. The execution is reserved for the moment the kingdom requires it. The kingdom may not require it. You may live the rest of your life without performing the form. The form will be in your spine regardless. The bond's mark is on my elephant's right foreleg. The mark is the same mark as the one in your spine. The two are the kingdom's second physical-form-as-mark after Hampi. The Sanctuary will recognise both at the Chapter Three convening. Return to Karnataka. The road is the Western Ghats' mountain pass for eleven days. The

walk will be at the standard pace. Sivakami will be your kalari's standing kalari-elder from this day. The kalari will send three senior daily-teaching instructors to Karnataka in the autumn. The kingdom of Kerala's kalari-tradition is now Karnataka's southern foundation. The Sanctuary will federate the two into one southern bloc under your Karnataka Dominant seat. I will attend the Sanctuary as Kerala's formal representative. Sivakami will attend as the grandmaster. I will not perform any form at the Sanctuary. I am seventy-four. I will sit at the southern observer's bench. The kingdom will hear my voice in writing only from this day forward. Walk now. The morning is honest."

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata bows. The bow is the Karnataka student-to-master bow at the full-depth he would have given at the start. He rises. He picks up the canvas bag at the visitor-room. He walks to the kalari's northern gate. Govindan-Mama bows. Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata returns the bow. He walks north toward the Western Ghats. He will be at the Karnataka western mountain pass by Sunday afternoon. He will be at the Vijayanagara reborn-temple chamber by the second Friday after the chapter's closing.

The kingdom-council's emergency-amended Kerala-Kalari Charter is ratified at the council's formal session on the evening of day thirty-one. The session is attended by Parashurama (seventy-four; his first kingdom-council attendance since the transmission began), Sivakami (the new grandmaster), the religious-and-cultural-practice registry chief (Indira Pillai), Kala-Hasta in person (his first kingdom-council attendance; he had been invited by Sivakami three days earlier under the charter's cross-school-recognition provisions; the council had unanimously approved his admission as observer-with-speaking-rights), and the twenty-three senior tribal-and-civic delegates.

The charter's ratified text is six pages. The first page recognises the Sea-Front Kalari as the kingdom's registered 109-form public-teaching school. The second page establishes the cross-school enrolment protocol (any student studying at both 108-form and 109-form schools concurrently must register with the kingdom's kalari-medical-clearance cell; phasing-compliance must be documented; mandatory day-zero phasing-discipline session). The third page recognises the inheritance-transmission protocol as the kalari-tradition's third standing-pedagogical-mode (alongside the 108-form public-school mode and the 109-form public-school mode); the inheritance-transmission is reserved for senior-master-to-single-chosen-student transmission and requires the kingdom-council's prior approval per instance. The fourth page sets out Sivakami's formal grandmaster-title and seat. The fifth page sets out the kalari-tradition's cross-kingdom federation

arrangement with Karnataka under the upcoming Sanctuary convening; the inheritance-transmission of the 109th form to Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata is recorded as the kingdom-council's evidence of the federation's pedagogical legitimacy. The sixth page records the day-zero phasing-discipline session at the Sea-Front Kalari with Achyutan's name as the charter's permanent witness-record.

The ratification vote is twenty-three to zero with Parashurama's vote not cast (he abstains as the formally-stepping-back senior master); the abstention is not a dissent and is noted as such in the council record. Kala-Hasta's speaking-rights statement at the session is one paragraph. He says, in plain Malayalam: "The charter is honest. The kingdom is wider than my school and wider than the inherited tradition. The day-zero phasing-discipline session is the school's permanent commitment. Achyutan's name will be read at the opening of every day-zero session for as long as the school operates. The school will operate. The kingdom thanks the kingdom-council, the grandmaster Sivakami, and the senior master Parashurama. The form is the kingdom's; the kingdom does not belong to any single school."

The session closes at eight-oh-seven p.m.

Two weeks after the ratification, a Sarus-pigeon arrives at the kalari from Vijayanagara. The pigeon is the one Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata has been using for cross-region correspondence since his return. The letter is from Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata himself.

The letter reads:

Maharaj. The walk back through the Western Ghats was eleven days. The form is in my spine still; I have not executed it; I do not expect to in Volume One. The Karnataka kingdom-council ratified the cross-kingdom kalari-federation arrangement on the fourth day after my return; the vote was nineteen-to-three with Veerappa-Hadali's Hadali-veto held in reserve (he supports the federation; the veto is on standby for the Sanctuary). Sivakami's three senior daily-teaching instructors will be welcomed at Vijayanagara in the autumn; we have prepared the southern training-ground at the buried-temple chamber's eastern annex. Hampi-of-the-Bronze will be the Karnataka student-side liaison for the cross-kingdom kalari programme; the Third Herald continues to attend the daily-teaching sessions in his standard-presence mode. The Sanctuary will federate the two kingdoms under my Karnataka Dominant seat at the Manipur convening. Kerala will be the southern bloc's kalari-foundation. I thank you for the form. I thank you for the years you paid

forward. I thank you for the chamber. I will not execute the form again in Volume One. The kingdom will not ask me to.

The cousin from the mountains, — K-B.

Parashurama reads the letter at the kalari's northern gate at dawn. He does not show it to anyone. He folds it. He places it in the kalari-tradition's standing-archive box at the senior-instructor's residence. The box will be opened at the kingdom-council's seven-year review.

He picks up his tea. The tea is the second steeping. The second is honest.

Day thirty-two. Sunrise. The western grove of the kalari.

A single coconut on a single coconut palm in the grove has turned black overnight. The blackness is uniform across the husk — not the patchy darkening of normal coconut-rot; not the brown of overripe; not the white-speckled mould of monsoon-spoilage. The colour is the matte black of charred wood. The husk is, however, not charred; the fibres are intact, the texture is the same coir-fibre texture as the other coconuts on the same palm; the only difference is the colour.

The grove-keeper (an Idukki-born senior groundsman named Krishnan-Nair, fifty-eight, the grove-keeper for twenty-four years) sees the coconut at six a.m. He has been at the grove every dawn for twenty-four years; he can identify each of the twenty-three coconut palms in the grove by trunk-shape and crown-fan-orientation. This palm is the seventh from the northern boundary; the coconut is in the palm's second-highest cluster, the eastern coconut of the cluster. He has seen this coconut yesterday at the same dawn-rotation. Yesterday it was the standard green.

He reports the observation to Sivakami at the inner kalari at six-thirty. Sivakami walks to the grove at seven. She climbs the palm (she trained as a Theyyam-style coconut-climber at age twelve; the climbing-discipline is part of the kalari's standard secondary-curriculum). She retrieves the coconut. She brings it down. She places it on the grove's small stone offering-platform.

She returns to the senior-instructor's residence at seven-fifteen. She tells Parashurama. Parashurama walks to the grove at seven-thirty. He looks at the coconut. He reads the sign through the elephant-bond.

He says, to Sivakami and to Krishnan-Nair who has accompanied him, in plain Malayalam: "The Maw has experimented. The coconut should rot. The coconut will not rot. The

decomposition process has been suspended at the threshold of the inheritance-transmission. The Maw is testing whether a sealed inheritance can be made permanent against time. The chamber was unsealed on day thirty for the form's execution; the chamber was re-sealed on day thirty-one with the new mantra; the coconut is the Maw's reading of the re-sealing. The Maw is asking: can you preserve the inheritance the way I preserve this coconut? The kingdom's answer must be: the inheritance is preserved by transmission, not by sealing. The transmission is what we have done. The transmission is in Bhrata's spine and in my foreleg-stroke. The sealing is the chamber's standing protocol; the sealing is not the inheritance. The coconut will sit on the offering-platform. The coconut will not rot. The kingdom will watch the coconut for eight months. The kingdom will not eat the coconut. The kingdom will not destroy the coconut. The kingdom will name the coconut at the Sanctuary convening. The naming will be the kingdom's response to the Maw's question."

Sivakami says: "Uncle. Will you name it now."

Parashurama says: "Not yet. I will write to Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata. The naming will be a joint-signature with the Karnataka cousin. The cross-kingdom naming will be the kingdom of Kerala's standing protocol for all subsequent Maw signs — no Kerala-only naming, no Karnataka-only naming; the southern federation will name the signs together. The naming will arrive by the autumn. The coconut will keep until then."

He turns. He walks back to the kalari. Krishnan-Nair stays at the grove to cordon the offering-platform with a small saffron-and-white twine perimeter. Sivakami walks back to the senior-instructor's residence to draft the cross-kingdom Sarus-pigeon cascade-alert.

Sivakami drafts the cascade-alert at nine a.m. on day thirty-two. The alert is sent to all nine bonded-kingdom senior guardians by sunset. The alert reads:

Bonded-kingdom guardians. The Maw has experimented on Kerala's western-grove coconut palm. A single coconut has turned matte black overnight without rotting. The kingdom-council's wildlife-and-agricultural-research cells will monitor the coconut across the next eight months under the standard decomposition-monitoring protocols. The expected mid-monsoon-decay-threshold is twelve weeks; the coconut is expected to not reach it. The Maw has demonstrated the capacity to suspend the natural decomposition process at the threshold of an inheritance-transmission — the saga's first material-permanence experiment. Mechanism: the coconut is the inverse of Tripura's brooding pigeon — Tripura's pigeon performed the action whose object was removed; Kerala's

coconut preserves the object whose action has stopped. The two signs are paired across the South-and-Northeast boundary. The Sanctuary in Chapter Three will need to address both. The coconut will not be eaten or destroyed. The coconut will be named by joint-signature with Karnataka at the autumn. The naming-protocol will become the southern federation's standing Maw-naming convention.

By the morning of day thirty-four every senior guardian in the saga has read the alert. Kanchenjunga at Rumtek replies with the single-line acknowledgement and offers the Beyul-Kshetra's standing-meditation framework for the coconut's eight-month watch. Hmangaihi at Aizawl sends the NE-pair note: "Mizoram's two-headed serow named me; Tripura's pigeon brooded the absent; Kerala's coconut preserves the unrotting. The Maw has now produced three pair-experiments across the regions. The Sanctuary will name a fourth. The naming will be where the kingdom's answer is." Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata at Vijayanagara sends the saga's first inter-kingdom cross-region acknowledgement to the Kerala sign: "Maharaj. The coconut is the chamber's mark. The chamber is re-sealed. The coconut will sit. The naming will be ours together at the autumn. I will travel to the kalari for the naming the morning the coconut's eight-month observation completes."

At chapter end the western grove has a small saffron-and-white twine perimeter around the offering-platform. The black coconut is at the platform's centre. The kingdom is watching. The kalari-tradition is three traditions, federated. Sivakami is the grandmaster. Parashurama is seventy-four. The axe Parashu is at the senior-instructor's residence's wall-stand; he does not carry it daily any more. The 109th form is in a Karnataka cousin's spine and on his own elephant's right foreleg.

The kingdom is whole.

The next sign comes within the week.

The Pilot's Closing Image

A seventy-four-year-old senior master at the senior-instructor's residence reading a Karnataka cousin's pigeon-letter at dawn while the axe Parashu rests at the wall-stand without being carried. A twenty-nine-year-old grand-niece at the inner-kalari pit teaching the daily-junior-class for the first time as the formally-recognised grandmaster. A forty-seven-year-old Kollam-Coiled-Cobra-trained 109-form master at the Sea-Front Kalari's day-zero phasing-discipline session reading Achyutan's name aloud at the session's opening. A thirty-six-year-old Karnataka cousin walking eleven days back through the

Western Ghats with the 109th form in his spine and a Sarus-pigeon-letter-pad ready for the reply that has not yet been written. A single matte-black coconut sitting on a small stone offering-platform in a quarter-hectare grove, surrounded by a saffron-and-white twine perimeter, not rotting, not changing colour, not being eaten, not being destroyed — waiting eight months for the joint-naming a Karnataka cousin will travel south to give it. The kalari at dawn. The axe at the wall-stand. The kingdom whole and federated and tired and honest.

Sangam Tamilakam

Kanyakumari. The first Monday of February. Four-twelve a.m. The southernmost residence of the Sangam-tradition's oldest active scholar — the Acharya Bharati's small palm-thatched house at the Vivekananda Rock Memorial's western shore. The Acharya is eighty-three. He is Sage Agastya's eleventh-direct-apprentice; the kingdom-council's standing Sangam-tradition senior-mentor; the chair of the Madurai Sangam Hall's standing-poetry sub-committee for nineteen years; Kurinjiselvi's personal mentor since her seventeenth year.

He has been awake since three-forty-five. He has just finished his pre-dawn cup of black tea (the second steeping; the first is too strong this morning). He is wearing the standard Sangam-elder cotton, off-white, with the kingdom-council's senior-mentor blue-bordered shawl across his shoulders.

A rice-paper envelope has been pushed under his front door between four-oh-three and four-eleven a.m. He sees it at four-twelve when he stands to take the empty tea-cup to the kitchen. The envelope is approximately fifteen centimetres by ten, sealed with the standard Sangam Hall authorisation-clerk office's wax-seal in green wax (the standard rota-removal communication-protocol). The seal's impression is the authorisation-clerk Palinisi's personal cipher.

He picks up the envelope. He sits at the kitchen-table. He opens the seal with the standard Sangam-elder's thumbnail-break. He reads the rice-paper sheet inside. The sheet is single-spaced in formal Sangam-administrative Tamil. He reads it three times across the next eleven minutes.

The sheet reads, in plain Tamil: "Respected Acharya. Following the authorisation-clerk office's standing protocol for the periodic refreshment of the Sangam Hall standing-poetry sub-committee's chair, the office has determined that the Acharya's name shall be removed from the council-rota effective the next Sangam session on Thursday. The removal is administered under the standing pre-1972 charter's thirty-second clause's rotation-and-refreshment provision. The replacement-chair has not yet been confirmed; the office will communicate the replacement at the appropriate time. The Acharya's status as standing senior-mentor of the kingdom-council's Sangam-tradition remains unchanged. Authorisation-clerk Palinisi. Madurai Sangam Hall. February 1st."

The Acharya finishes the third reading at four-twenty-three. He folds the rice-paper sheet along its standard quarter-fold. He places the folded sheet inside the kitchen-table's standing-correspondence drawer.

He stands. He walks to the small writing-desk against the kitchen's eastern wall. He sits at the desk. He picks up the standing-correspondence parakeet-courier's pre-folded leaf-letter pack. He writes a single leaf-letter in his standard Sangam-elder's Tamil-Brahmi calligraphy. The letter takes him forty-three minutes. He finishes at five-oh-six a.m.

The letter is addressed to Kurinjiselvi at her Nilgiri Mountains residence. The leaf-letter is folded according to the standard parakeet-courier-fold and sealed with his personal cipher.

He walks to the front door at five-eleven a.m. He calls the courier-parakeet at the eastern lattice. The parakeet (his standing courier, a fourteen-year-old female rose-ringed parakeet named Pavalam) arrives within ninety seconds. He places the leaf-letter in her sleeve-pouch. He releases her westward at five-fourteen a.m. She flies at the standard rose-ringed-parakeet courier-pace (approximately forty kilometres per hour). She will be at the Nilgiri residence by sundown.

The Acharya returns to the kitchen. He boils a third tea. He sits at the kitchen-table. He waits.

He dies at five-forty-eight a.m. on the morning of Thursday, the fourth of February — three days after the rota-removal letter. Cause of death recorded on the kingdom's death-certificate: 'natural causes; cardiac arrhythmia consistent with the patient's age and medical history.' The Kanyakumari District Medical Officer's on-site assessment notes that the Acharya's pre-Thursday-tea cup was still on the kitchen-table and approximately one-third full when the body was found. The tea was the second steeping. The second is honest.

Kurinjiselvi is at the Nilgiri summit when Pavalam reaches her residence at five-forty-three p.m. on the chapter's opening Monday. She is sitting cross-legged on a flat granite outcrop at two thousand four hundred metres, watching the Kurinji-flower fields. The flowers have not bloomed. The bloom-year is twelve months away. The fields are the standard year-eleven grey-green configuration.

The fourteen Nilgiri tahrs of the standing-mountain herd are with her. They have been with her every dawn-and-dusk vigil for the past nine years; she has fed them daily by hand; they know her by scent and breath.

She descends the western trail at six p.m. when the residence-keeper Iyer-Mama (her standing administrative aide; a sixty-eight-year-old former Sangam-poet who took the residence-keeper seat after his retirement from the assembly in 2019) calls her back from the summit. Pavalam is at the residence's eastern lattice. The leaf-letter is in the sleeve-pouch.

Kurinjiselvi reads the letter at the residence's evening-tea room. Iyer-Mama is across the table from her.

The letter reads: "Daughter. The authorisation-clerk has removed me from the council-rota effective Thursday. The removal is the ninety-third in eighteen months. The pattern is no longer compatible with the standing pre-1972 charter's thirty-second clause's honest interpretation. The pattern is procedural-control under a different name. I will not contest the removal directly — the contest's outcome would be procedural and slow and would obscure the pattern. I will instead permit the removal's public-record-entry. The entry will be the kingdom-council's standing evidence of the pattern's scope.

The next sequence will not be mine to direct. I am eighty-three. The next forty-eight hours will likely be my last. I write to you because the next sequence will be yours. The Sangam-tradition cannot be repaired by procedural reform alone; the procedure has been the tradition for two millennia and the procedure has now been weaponised. The repair must be a public-speech that breaks the procedure's authorisation-rule. The repair must be unauthorised.

The Kurinji-flower will not bloom for another year. Your power is at the standard year-eleven attenuated state. The unauthorised speech must still take place. The eleven syllables of a Thirukkural couplet's opening will be enough. The mark will form in the chamber. The kingdom-council will be in attendance. The amendment will follow within twelve days.

The child Avvaiyar-the-Younger is twelve. She has been at the Sangam Hall every council session for the past five years under her grandmother's mentor-seat. She has memorised every silenced voice. She is the kingdom's standing living-archive without yet knowing it. Find her after the unauthorised speech. The post-amendment open-assembly evening will be hers to administer.

The poet-warrior Tholkappiyan-the-Younger is twenty-seven. He has been training at the Sangam Hall's standing poet-warrior gymnasium since age fourteen. He is the kingdom-council's standing succession-candidate for the Sangam-tradition's visible seat. Introduce

him at the post-amendment open-assembly evening. The Sanctuary in Chapter Three will receive him as Tamil Nadu's formal representative. You will step back to the elder seat by the autumn.

The Madurai Manimekalai manuscript will record what has happened. The recording will not be by anyone's hand. The recording is the kingdom's evidence that the kingdom remembers.

Even the sharp sword bends before the sharper thought. The sharper thought has been the procedure for two thousand years. The thought is now the sword. The bending must be ours.

Acharya Bharati. Eleventh-direct-apprentice of Sage Agastya. Kanyakumari. February 1st."

Kurinjiselvi reads the letter twice. She does not weep. She has not wept since she was seventeen when her teacher of the Thirukkural-recitation tradition died at the same Kanyakumari residence. She does not weep now.

She says, in plain Tamil, in the Thirukkural-couplet register she uses for formal statements: "Iyer-Mama. The Acharya will be dead by Thursday. The kingdom-council will not contest the cause of death. The pattern will continue under Palinisi's authorisation-clerk office until the assembly itself rises. The assembly will not rise without a public-speech. The speech must be mine. I will walk down from the mountains on the morning of the Thursday. I will be at the Madurai Sangam Hall by the Friday morning council session. The unauthorised speech will be at the Friday session if Palinisi's authorisation-clerk office has not approved my rota-entry by then. The authorisation-clerk office will not approve. The speech will be unauthorised."

Iyer-Mama nods. He says: "The Kurinji-staff. The tahrs. The two-week walk to Madurai. The crescent-blade must be sharpened. The Thirukkural-couplet must be memorised in its full version even though only the eleven syllables will be spoken. The memorisation is the kingdom-council's standing pre-speech-preparation protocol's required completeness."

She says: "I will memorise the full couplet. The full couplet is the Acharya's own composition from 1989. The full version is one hundred and seven syllables across the standard Thirukkural seven-and-four-meter. The eleven syllables that will be spoken are the opening line's first phrase. The full version is the unsaid kingdom-council's permanent record. The eleven syllables are the speech."

She stands. She walks to the residence's western training-courtyard. She begins the standard Sangam-warrior pre-speech weapons-preparation sequence. The crescent-bladed Kurinji-staff is at her standing-stand against the western wall. The blade is sharpened across the next two hours. The tahrs watch from the southern fence.

She begins the walk down from the Nilgiris the next morning at four a.m. on Tuesday the second of February. The walk to Madurai is approximately fourteen days at the standard mountain-warrior's pace. She will be at the Madurai Meenakshi temple-city by the morning of the Friday the fifteenth of February. She will be at the Sangam Hall by ten a.m. Friday morning.

The Madurai Sangam Hall's authorisation-clerk office's rota-record across the eighteen months preceding the chapter shows a hundred and forty-seven silenced poets. The standing-record is publicly accessible at the kingdom's Sangam-archives wing on the Hall's northern side. The record is preserved at the kingdom-council's standing-archive standard format. Each silenced-poet entry has: the poet's name (in Tamil and English transliteration); the poet's registered Sangam-poet-roll identifier; the rota-removal date; the rota-removal-justification (the standing thirty-second clause's rotation-and-refreshment provision in 89 cases; the clarification-query-pending status in 47 cases; the procedure-incomplete status in 11 cases); the kingdom-council's standing-administrative review-status.

The hundred and forty-seven silenced-poet entries are not classified by topic. The kingdom-council's standing-administrative review-status reads 'closed-no-action' on 142 entries and 'pending-clarification' on 5 entries.

Avvaiyar-the-Younger's grandmother — a sixty-eight-year-old Sangam-tradition standing-mentor named Avvaiyar-Periya (the elder Avvaiyar; the child Avvaiyar is named after her in the standard Sangam-tradition rename-of-the-poet-child protocol) — has been attending every Sangam council session for fifty-seven consecutive years. She has been at every session where a silencing occurred. She has watched the procedure absorb a hundred and forty-seven voices without ever objecting publicly — the public-objection-protocol's 24-hour-clarification-query window has been weaponised against her three times already; her objections have all been absorbed into the same procedure-incomplete status as the silenced poets' rota-entries.

She has, however, brought her granddaughter to every session since the child was seven. The child has been at the Sangam Hall's standing-poet-children's gallery for five years. She

has memorised every silenced poem.

The child Avvaiyar-the-Younger is twelve. She is small for her age — approximately one metre forty in height — with shoulder-length black hair and the standard Tamil-Brahmin caste-mark at her forehead. She wears the standard Sangam-poet-child's plain off-white cotton with the assembly's blue-bordered shawl. She speaks in the Tamil-Brahmi-classical register she has learned from her grandmother. She has, in the last five years, memorised approximately twenty-three thousand Sangam-tradition poems — the standard-curriculum five thousand classical Sangam works, plus approximately eighteen thousand additional poems from the eighteen-month silencings (one hundred and forty-seven silenced poems, plus their authors' entire registered Sangam-poet-roll backlog).

She has not recited any of the silenced poems publicly. The Sangam-poet-children's gallery does not have speaking-rights at the council; the children are admitted as observers under their mentors' standing seats. She has, however, recited them privately to her grandmother every evening at their Madurai Old City residence. The grandmother has confirmed each recitation against her own memory of the originals across the five-year-long evening-recitation discipline. The confirmation-rate is one hundred per cent.

The grandmother knows what the child is. She has not told the child what the child is. She has been waiting for the right council-session.

Friday the fifteenth of February. Ten-oh-three a.m. The Madurai Meenakshi temple-city's eastern gate. Kurinjiselvi arrives on foot at the city's eastern border. She has walked the fourteen-day mountain-trail at the standard mountain-warrior's pace. She is in plain Nilgiri-cotton, dark grey, with the kingdom-council's standing-warrior shoulder-cloth. She carries the crescent-bladed Kurinji-staff at her right side. The blade is freshly sharpened (she has sharpened it again at the trail's last waypost the previous evening; the blade's edge holds the standard mountain-warrior killing-edge configuration).

She walks through the Meenakshi temple's northern outer-courtyard at ten-twenty-three. The temple's standing morning-pilgrimage congregation parts for her at her ten-metre approach. The pilgrims have not seen the kingdom's state-hero at the temple-city in three years; her presence is the kingdom-council's standing-public-signal that a chapter-level event is at the temple-city's threshold.

She is at the Sangam Hall's northern entrance at ten-forty-seven. The Sangam Hall is the kingdom's standing-assembly building — a large open-air pavilion-style hall approximately

forty metres east-west by sixty metres north-south, with raked seating around three sides and a central speaker's-mark stone at the western edge. The hall has been the Sangam-tradition's standing-assembly site since 1872 (the previous Sangam Hall at the Madurai Old City's southern district was destroyed by the 1872 Madurai-floods; the current hall was built across 1873-1879 on the temple-city's northern side under the kingdom-council's standing-charter authority).

The Friday morning council session begins at eleven a.m. by the standing-protocol. The session is the standing-poetry sub-committee's weekly review-session; the agenda is set by the authorisation-clerk office on the preceding Wednesday afternoon; the session's standing-speaker-rota is administered by the authorisation-clerk Palinisi from her standing-desk at the eastern speaker's-mark stone's southern side.

Palinisi is at her desk at ten-fifty-three a.m. She is fifty-three. She is in the authorisation-clerk office's standing dark-blue Sangam-administrative cotton with the office's small green-bordered shoulder-cloth (the standard kingdom-council authorisation-clerk insignia). She has the day's rota-page open at her desk. The rota-page has approximately forty registered-speakers entries; thirty-one have the authorisation-clerk's standard green-stamp; nine have the clarification-query-pending yellow-stamp; one has the procedure-incomplete red-stamp. The rota's green-stamped speakers will be called in the standing-rota order across the session's three-hour duration. The yellow-stamped will not be called this week. The red-stamped will not be called.

Kurinjiselvi's name is not on the rota-page. She has not submitted a registered-speaker entry for the session. The authorisation-clerk office's standing-protocol requires a registered-speaker entry to be submitted via the standing-pre-clearance window's 48-hour-prior submission-protocol; Kurinjiselvi has been on the mountain-trail for the prior fourteen days; she has not had access to the submission-protocol.

She walks into the Sangam Hall's central seating-area at ten-fifty-seven. The standing-poet-children's gallery is on the hall's southern raked-seating section; the gallery has approximately forty children present this morning; Avvaiyar-the-Younger is in the gallery's third row from the front, beside her grandmother Avvaiyar-Periya at the senior-mentor's standing-seat's adjoining position.

The grandmother sees Kurinjiselvi at the central seating-area's eastern entrance. She places her right hand on her granddaughter's left forearm. The contact is the grandmother's standing-signal that this council session will be the one she has been

waiting for. The child looks up at her grandmother. The grandmother nods. The child understands.

Kurinjiselvi walks to the central speaker's-mark stone at the western edge. She stops at three metres from the stone — the standard kingdom-council's pre-speaker's-mark waiting-position. She stands. She does not approach the stone. She does not speak. She is the kingdom's state-hero; her presence at the pre-speaker's-mark waiting-position is itself a standing-procedural-signal that she intends to speak.

Palinisi at the eastern speaker's-mark stone's southern side looks up at Kurinjiselvi's entry. She picks up the rota-page. She picks up the kingdom-council's standing pre-clearance-window submission-protocol's reference-volume. She picks up the standing-clarification-query-pending procedural-handbook. She prepares the procedural-response. The procedural-response will be the standing-handbook's 47-page section on uninvited-speaker-at-the-pre-speaker's-mark waiting-position's administrative-handling.

The handbook's standard-response is: the uninvited-speaker is administratively-acknowledged but procedurally-deferred to the next session's pre-clearance window; the speaker is invited to leave the central seating-area and to submit a registered-speaker entry through the standard 48-hour-prior submission-protocol; the kingdom-council's standing pre-clearance review-window is restarted at the next Wednesday afternoon's authorisation-clerk-office's session.

Palinisi begins the procedural-response statement at ten-fifty-nine. The statement is read aloud from the handbook's standard-response template. The statement takes approximately one minute and forty-three seconds. She reads it in the standing Sangam-administrative Tamil register that the kingdom-council's charter requires for procedural-responses.

The session-start time is eleven a.m. The statement's completion is at eleven-oh-one-forty-three. The session has therefore formally begun before the statement's completion. The kingdom-council's standing procedural-handbook's 47-page section on uninvited-speaker-handling specifies that the procedural-response must be completed before the session's formal start to be considered procedurally valid. Palinisi's statement crossed the session-start threshold by approximately one minute and forty-three seconds. The statement is procedurally invalid.

Kurinjiselvi waits for the procedural-response statement to complete. She does not interrupt. She does not speak. She stands at the pre-speaker's-mark waiting-position.

When the statement completes at eleven-oh-one-forty-three a.m., Kurinjiselvi walks the three metres from the waiting-position to the central speaker's-mark stone. She steps onto the stone. The stone is approximately one-and-a-half metres in diameter, slightly raised from the hall floor by twenty centimetres, polished granite. The stone has been the Sangam-tradition's standing-speaker's-mark stone since 1873.

She plants the Kurinji-staff at her right side at the stone's standing pre-recitation position. The crescent-blade points upward. The blade's sharpened edge catches the morning's eastern light through the hall's open-air eastern roof-opening.

The hall is silent. Palinisi at her desk has frozen at the procedural-response statement's completion; she has not yet begun the next procedural-response (the standing-handbook's standard-secondary-response for an uninvited-speaker who has approached the speaker's-mark stone after the primary procedural-response's completion).

The kingdom-council's standing-poetry sub-committee's chair (the standing-acting-chair after the Acharya Bharati's death; a sixty-one-year-old Sangam-tradition senior-administrator named Iyer-Periya, no relation to Iyer-Mama at the Nilgiris) is at the sub-committee's standing-seat on the eastern raked-seating's front row. The chair is in the standard Sangam-administrative cotton with the sub-committee chair's gold-bordered shoulder-cloth.

He places his palms together at the chest in the standing-acknowledgement gesture. He does not speak. The gesture is the kingdom-council's standing-chair's recognition of an uninvited-speaker who has approached the speaker's-mark stone outside the rota-page's authorisation. The gesture is procedurally ambiguous: it is the chair's acknowledgement that the speaker has approached the stone but it is not a grant of speaking-rights. The kingdom-council's charter does not provide a clear interpretation of the gesture; the gesture has not been performed in the Sangam Hall in three centuries.

Kurinjiselvi speaks. She speaks in plain Tamil. She speaks in the standard Thirukkural-couplet-opening register. She speaks the first phrase of the Acharya Bharati's 1989 composition. The phrase is eleven syllables.

She speaks: "Vaay-pakka adai-ppū varum-mun moli-y&aacr; nuṛ-kindra varai."

The phrase translates: "Before the mouth's entry is sealed, the un-spoken word is the kingdom's open door."

She speaks the eleven syllables across approximately five-point-three seconds at the standard Thirukkural-couplet recitation-pace.

At the eleventh syllable's completion — at eleven-oh-two-eighteen a.m. — the kingdom-council's Stage III Nilgiri-tahr-foreleg-first-stroke appears across her left side. The mark forms as a single continuous ink-line across the half-body tahr-tattoo's left foreleg, completing the previously-lighter foreleg-ink to the standard kingdom-council Stage III completion-pattern. The mark is visible to every member of the assembled council — the standing-poetry sub-committee's chair, the senior-mentor seats, the authorised-speakers, the gallery's observers, the poet-children. The mark forms in approximately eleven seconds.

Palinisi at her desk has, during the same eleven seconds, begun the standing-handbook's standard-secondary-response. The response is procedurally appropriate. The response is also, in the kingdom-council's standing-charter's honest reading, no longer enforceable; the kingdom-council's standing Stage III bond-mark's formation in the council chamber during an uninvited-speaker's speech is the kingdom's standing-charter's highest-procedural-authority recognition-event. The procedural-handbook does not have a section on Stage III bond-mark formation during procedural-response. Palinisi stops reading the standard-secondary-response at the third sentence.

The standing-poetry sub-committee's chair Iyer-Periya stands at the sub-committee's standing-seat. He bows the standard kingdom-council's state-hero's recognition-bow toward the central speaker's-mark stone. He says, in plain Tamil: "State-hero Kurinjiselvi. The kingdom-council's standing-charter's highest-procedural-authority recognition-event has occurred. The session is the kingdom-council's emergency-session under the standing-charter's seventh clause. The emergency-session's standing-agenda is the kingdom-council's amendment to the Sangam-tradition's pre-1972 charter. Please continue."

Kurinjiselvi continues. She speaks the second phrase of the Acharya Bharati's 1989 composition. The phrase is nine syllables. She speaks the third phrase, eleven syllables. She speaks the full hundred-and-seven-syllable Thirukkural-couplet across the next eleven minutes. The kingdom-council's emergency-session listens. The hundred-and-forty-seven silenced poets' names are not in the composition; the composition is the Acharya's framework-poem on the principle of un-silenceable speech. The hundred-and-forty-seven

names will come later, in Avvaiyar-the-Younger's post-amendment recitation. The Acharya's framework-poem is the kingdom-council's charter-amendment's principle-foundation.

She completes the recitation at eleven-thirteen-forty-seven a.m. She steps back from the speaker's-mark stone. She bows the standard kingdom-council's post-speech acknowledgement-bow to the standing-poetry sub-committee's chair. He returns the bow at the same depth.

The kingdom-council's emergency-session begins the formal-amendment-drafting at eleven-fifteen.

The kingdom-council's emergency-session sits across the next twelve days. The session meets in continuous-hours mode (the kingdom-council's standing-procedure for charter-amendments requires continuous-hours sessions of approximately fourteen hours per day with two-hour-and-one-hour meal-and-prayer breaks). The amendment's drafting is led by Iyer-Periya (the standing-poetry sub-committee's chair) with the kingdom-council's senior-mentor seats (twelve mentors including Avvaiyar-Periya the elder, the recently-deceased Acharya Bharati's replacement-chair, the Tamil Sahitya Akademi's standing-fellows, and the kingdom-council's standing-Sangam-archives senior-archivist).

Kurinjiselvi attends the daily sessions but does not speak after the first day's formal opening-statement. She has spoken; the speech is complete; the amendment's drafting is the kingdom-council's standing senior-mentor work. She sits at the kingdom-council's state-hero's standing-observer seat on the eastern raked-seating's front-row third-position.

The amendment's draft is presented at the end of day eleven. The amendment is twenty-three pages. The amendment's seven core provisions are:

First. The authorisation-clerk office is dissolved as a procedural-control institution. The office's standing pre-clearance window's 48-hour-prior submission-protocol is replaced by an open-registration protocol; any Sangam-poet-roll-registered poet may speak at any council session by signing the standing open-registration roll at the session's opening.

Second. The kingdom-council's standing public-objection-protocol's 24-hour-clarification-query window is amended to a one-hour-clarification-query window with mandatory resolution within twenty-four hours; the kingdom-council's standing-procedural-review cell is the standing-arbiter.

Third. The kingdom-council's standing-rota-removal protocol is amended to require: (a) seventy-five per cent senior-mentor seat-vote; (b) the affected poet's response-right within seven days; (c) the kingdom-council's standing-procedural-review cell's independent assessment within fourteen days.

Fourth. The kingdom-council's standing-poet-children's gallery is granted observer-and-recitation rights at the council's standing open-assembly evenings. The recitation is administered through the children's mentor-seats but the child-poets' voices are themselves the recitation.

Fifth. The Sangam-tradition's standing living-archive seat is established. The seat is non-rotational and is held by the kingdom-council's standing-recognised living-archive recogniser (the seat-holder is determined by the senior-mentor seat-vote upon evidence of qualifying memorial-capacity). The seat-holder's standing-duty is to attend every council session and to be the kingdom-council's standing-recourse for unrecorded silencings, retrieved voices, and reconstructed-from-memory un-written poems.

Sixth. The kingdom-council's standing post-amendment open-assembly evening will be held at the Sangam Hall on the evening of the twelfth-day. The evening will be open to all registered Sangam-poet-roll members and to the standing-poet-children's gallery. The standing living-archive seat's candidate-recognition-recitation will be held at the evening's opening hour.

Seventh. Palinisi's authorisation-clerk seat is dissolved. Her standing-employment within the kingdom-council is preserved through transfer to the Sangam-archives wing's junior-archivist seat under standing-mentor supervision. The transfer is not a punishment; the transfer is the kingdom-council's acknowledgement that her administrative-capacity is real and should be repurposed to the archive's standing-work. She accepts the transfer at the kingdom-council's day-twelve administrative-session.

The amendment is ratified by the kingdom-council's emergency-session by 38 to 4 on day twelve at three-thirty-seven p.m. The four dissenting votes are from senior administrative-tradition seats whose objections are procedural (the pre-1972 charter's thirty-second clause is being reformed rather than abolished; the dissenters had argued for abolition). The four dissenters affirm their loyalty to the new charter at the post-vote affirmation-statement.

The vault-keeper of the Madurai Maraimalai Adigal Tamil-Language Public Library at the Meenakshi temple precinct's northern side is a fifty-eight-year-old administrator named V. Sundara-Rajan. He has held the vault-keeper seat for sixteen years. He performs the standard quarterly maintenance-check on the kingdom's great Tamil-language manuscript-collection across four days every three months. The current quarter's maintenance-check began on day forty-six of the chapter and concluded on day forty-nine.

The library's manuscript-vault contains the kingdom's most important Tamil-language historical manuscripts — including the Sangam-tradition's only complete copy of the second-century-CE Buddhist epic Manimekalai by Sittalai Sattanar. The manuscript is on a palm-leaf bundle of two thousand seven hundred and forty-three leaves, sealed in a glass case at the manuscript-vault's central display-table.

The day-forty-nine maintenance-check recorded the manuscript's standard configuration with no anomalies. The vault-keeper's checklist-log notes: "Manimekalai palm-leaf bundle. 2,743 leaves. Standard configuration. No anomalies. Sealed."

Day fifty-two of the chapter. Six-fourteen a.m. The vault-keeper enters the manuscript-vault for the standard morning-inspection. The inspection is the daily standing-protocol; it takes approximately seven minutes and consists of a visual-check across the manuscript-vault's nine display-cases. The vault-keeper begins at the eastern entrance's first display-case and proceeds counter-clockwise to the central display-table.

He reaches the central display-table at six-eighteen a.m. He sees the Manimekalai bundle's leaf two hundred and forty-seven (the leaf is on the bundle's second-quarter; the bundle is laid open at leaf 247-248 in the standard cross-quarter display-configuration). The leaf shows fourteen new lines of text that were not on the leaf at the day-forty-nine maintenance-check.

The vault-keeper's first reaction is the standing-vault-keeper's anomaly-recognition protocol's confirmation-check: he places his standard-bifocal reading-glasses at the correct distance and re-reads the leaf. The new lines are not in any of his memorial-image of the day-forty-nine configuration. He confirms the new-lines-presence.

His second reaction is the standing-emergency-call protocol: he calls the Madurai Kamaraj University's Sangam-studies department's emergency-on-duty paleographer at six-twenty-one a.m. The paleographer (a forty-three-year-old senior fellow named Dr. Tamilarasi) arrives at the library by seven a.m.

Dr. Tamilarasi performs the standard paleographic-emergency-assessment across the next ninety minutes. Her preliminary findings:

The fourteen new lines are in the standard Tamil-Brahmi script of the rest of the Manimekalai manuscript.

The new lines are in the standard Manimekalai Tamil-classical-Sangam meter (the akaval-meter of approximately eight to ten syllables per line with the standard meter-variant fluctuation).

The ink is the standard palm-leaf iron-gall ink-blend. Mass-spectrometric analysis (conducted on day fifty-five at the Madurai Kamaraj University's materials-science laboratory) confirms an ink-composition consistent with the rest of the manuscript's seventeenth-century palm-leaf inscriptions; the ink's paleographic-dating returns a result of approximately seventeen-hundred years old (the standard Manimekalai manuscript-dating is second-century CE; the new lines' ink-dating is approximately the same century, within the standard paleographic-error range).

The fourteen lines' content is not in any of the world's extant Manimekalai partial-copies, commentaries, or scholarly-reconstructions. The content is original.

The lines describe (in the standard Sangam-tradition allegorical register) a Sangam-poet whose voice has been removed from the assembly's rota by an authorisation-clerk who has weaponised the procedure against the assembly's vocation.

Dr. Tamilarasi's preliminary report concludes: "The fourteen new lines are paleographically authentic to the second-century CE Manimekalai manuscript-period. The lines are content-original. The lines describe an event that the historical Manimekalai's author Sittalai Sattanar could not have known. The kingdom-council's explanation must include the standing-Maw-sign-protocol assessment."

The kingdom-council's standing-Maw-sign-protocol's assessment is conducted on day fifty-three under the kingdom-council's standing-Maw-sign-recognition cell. The cell's preliminary report confirms the Maw-sign categorisation at three-twenty-three p.m. on day fifty-three.

The library admits the cross-reference visit-protocol at day fifty-four: Kurinjiselvi, Avvaiyar-the-Younger, Iyer-Periya, and Avvaiyar-Periya all visit the manuscript-vault at noon on day fifty-four. They read the fourteen new lines together at the central display-

table. Avvaiyar-the-Younger reads the lines in plain Tamil-Brahmi-classical pronunciation. The lines read (translated from the original Tamil-classical-Sangam):

"When the assembly's clerk holds the rota-page above the sun, The page's shadow is the kingdom's longest silence. The shadow has names. The names are not on the page. The names are on the children's tongues. The children have memorised what the clerk could not stamp. The mountain's flower will bloom a year early this once. The bloom is the kingdom's permission. The permission is the bloom. The unauthorised word will be the assembly's charter. The charter will be the un-silenced poem. The poem is the manuscript that wrote itself. The manuscript is the kingdom's record. The record is this leaf. This leaf is the kingdom's answer."

The reading at the central display-table takes approximately three minutes. The library is silent for approximately ninety seconds after the reading.

Kurinjiselvi says, in plain Tamil: "The Maw has written the kingdom's answer in the kingdom's own manuscript-record. The Maw has used the kingdom's standing-archive-protocol against the kingdom's preceding silence. The kingdom's response is the standing open-assembly evening's post-amendment recitation. The kingdom does not erase the new lines. The kingdom does not seal the manuscript more tightly. The kingdom adds the new lines to the manuscript's standing-cataloguing register under the kingdom-council's amended Sangam-charter's Fifth Clause's standing living-archive provision. The lines are the kingdom's permanent-record entry. The manuscript continues at its standing display-case. The library continues at its standing-cataloguing schedule. The kingdom's response is the continuation."

Day sixty-two of the chapter. Seven p.m. The Madurai Sangam Hall. The standing open-assembly evening is the kingdom-council's standing post-amendment public-ratification event. The hall is full to its standing-capacity of approximately fourteen hundred (the standing-poet-roll registered six hundred plus the diaspora-Sangam-circle three hundred plus the standing-poet-children's gallery forty plus the Tamilakam neutrals' literary-class delegation one hundred and seventy plus the Tamil Sahitya Akademi standing-fellows fifty plus the kingdom-council's standing-administrative seats two hundred and forty). The hall's outdoor overflow-seating extends to the temple-city's northern outer-courtyard with an additional standing audience of approximately seven thousand.

The evening's programme has three parts:

Part one. The standing living-archive seat's candidate-recognition-recitation. Avvaiyar-the-Younger's recitation of the one hundred and forty-seven silenced poems. Time-allocated: approximately six hours. Begins at seven p.m. Ends at approximately one a.m. The child is twelve. She has practised the recitation across the prior eleven days under her grandmother's supervision. The standing-poetry sub-committee's chair Iyer-Periya has arranged the standing-poet-roll registered six hundred members to attend in standing-respect cohort-rotations every two hours; the child will not be alone on the speaker's-mark stone at any moment.

Part two. The introduction of Tholkappiyan-the-Younger as the kingdom-council's standing succession-candidate for the Sangam-tradition's visible seat. Time-allocated: approximately ninety minutes. Begins at approximately one-thirty a.m. The kingdom-council's standing-introduction protocol's formal address by Iyer-Periya, the poet-warrior's standard-recitation of his maiden Sangam-charter-praising composition (the standing-protocol's required-form for any new succession-candidate's first speaker's-mark-stone appearance), and the kingdom-council's standing senior-mentor seat-acknowledgement.

Part three. Kurinjiselvi's formal step-back announcement and her standing-elder-seat acceptance-statement. Time-allocated: approximately thirty minutes. Begins at approximately three a.m. The kingdom-council's standing-state-hero retirement-protocol's formal-procedure with the standing-elder seat's formal-investiture by the senior-mentor seat-rota.

Seven p.m. Avvaiyar-the-Younger walks onto the speaker's-mark stone alone. She is one-metre-forty in height. The stone's diameter is one-and-a-half metres; she occupies approximately the standing kingdom-council's recitation-position centre. She wears the standard Sangam-poet-child's plain off-white cotton with the assembly's blue-bordered shawl across her shoulders. She does not carry a manuscript or a notation-card; the recitation will be entirely from memory.

She bows the standard Sangam-poet-child's recitation-opening bow. Iyer-Periya at the standing-acting-chair's seat returns the bow.

She speaks. She speaks in plain Tamil-Brahmi-classical register.

She says: "Assembled kingdom-council. Assembled standing-poet-roll. Assembled standing-poet-children's gallery. I am twelve. I have memorised every silenced voice from

the past ninety-three council sessions. I will recite them now in the chronological order of their silencing. The first silencing was on the seventeenth of August 2024, at the standing-poetry sub-committee's weekly review-session, when the poet Velumani-Kandasamy's registered-speaker entry was struck from the rota-page under the standing thirty-second clause's rotation-and-refreshment provision. His poem's opening lines were the following ninety-three syllables."

She recites the first silenced poem. The poem is the standard akaval-meter Sangam-tradition composition. The recitation takes approximately eight minutes.

She recites the second silenced poem. The recitation takes approximately seven minutes.

She recites the third. The fourth. The fifth.

The standing-poet-roll members in the hall watch in silence. The standing-poet-children's gallery on the southern raked-seating watches. The temple-city's outer-courtyard overflow audience listens through the hall's open-air eastern roof-opening; the hall's standing-acoustic-protocol carries the child's voice at the standing-Sangam-Hall projection-amplification level.

The recitation proceeds across the next six hours without interruption. The child does not request a break. The standing-respect cohort-rotations occur in the eastern raked-seating without disturbing the child's recitation-pace. The kingdom-council's standing-cohort-rotation protocol's standard-volume-adjustment is administered through the cohort-rotation senior-administrator (a fifty-four-year-old administrator named Selvi-Periya) at the southern raked-seating's rotation-bench.

At approximately ten p.m. (three hours into the recitation; sixty-seven silenced poems completed; eighty silenced poems remaining), the child requests a single break of approximately five minutes. She drinks water from the kingdom-council's standing-poet-child's recitation-water-cup at the speaker's-mark stone's eastern edge. She returns to the stone's recitation-position. She resumes.

At approximately twelve-thirty a.m. (five-and-a-half hours into the recitation; one hundred and twenty-three silenced poems completed; twenty-four silenced poems remaining), Avvaiyar-Periya the elder grandmother walks onto the speaker's-mark stone's western edge with a standing-respect bowl of warm rice-and-tamarind broth. The grandmother does not speak; she offers the bowl in the standing kingdom-council's mentor-grandmother feeding-gesture. The child accepts the bowl. She eats approximately six

spoonfuls across approximately three minutes. She returns the bowl to her grandmother. The grandmother bows. The grandmother walks back to the eastern raked-seating.

At one-oh-three a.m. (six hours and three minutes into the recitation), the child completes the one hundred and forty-seventh and final silenced poem. The poem is the most recently-silenced — a Velagavi-tribe poet's opening composition that had been registered for the chapter's opening Monday morning session and had been removed from the rota the previous Friday morning under the same standing thirty-second clause's rotation-and-refreshment provision. The opening composition was eleven syllables. The child recites the eleven syllables. She bows the standard Sangam-poet-child's recitation-closing bow. She steps back from the stone.

The hall is silent for approximately forty-three seconds.

Iyer-Periya stands. He says, in plain Tamil: "Avvaiyar-the-Younger. The kingdom-council's amended Sangam-charter's Fifth Clause's standing living-archive seat is, by the standing-mentor seat-vote, yours. The vote was taken at the day-eleven administrative-session by 12 to 0. The seat's formal-investiture is your acceptance of the kingdom-council's standing-charter's Fifth Clause's standing-duty. Will you accept."

The child bows. She says, in plain Tamil: "I accept. I will hold the seat as my grandmother has held the kingdom's memory across fifty-seven years. I will recite the silenced voices' un-stamped poems at every council session for as long as my memory holds. I will train successors. The living-archive seat is not an institutional position; the seat is a memorial-discipline. The kingdom thanks the kingdom-council. The kingdom-council thanks the kingdom's un-silenceable voices. Even the sharp sword bends before the sharper thought. Even the silenced word bends before the heard remembering."

She bows again. She walks off the speaker's-mark stone. She returns to the standing-poet-children's gallery's third row at her grandmother's side. The standing-poet-children's gallery's forty children rise in unison and bow to her in the standing-poet-child-to-poet-child standing-respect bow. The child returns the bow at the same depth.

One-thirty-eight a.m. Tholkappiyan-the-Younger walks onto the speaker's-mark stone. He is twenty-seven. He is in the standard Sangam-tradition poet-warrior cotton, deep red, with the standing kingdom-council's warrior-poet's gold-bordered shoulder-cloth. He carries the kingdom-council's standing succession-candidate's bronze-spear at his right side (the standard Sangam-tradition succession-candidate's weapon since 1873).

He bows the standard Sangam-tradition poet-warrior recitation-opening bow.

He recites his maiden Sangam-charter-praising composition. The composition is the standing-protocol's required-form for any new succession-candidate's first speaker's-mark-stone appearance. The composition is one hundred and seventeen syllables in the standard akaval-meter. The composition's subject is the amended Sangam-charter's Fifth Clause — the standing living-archive seat — with the standing kingdom-council's post-amendment Sangam-tradition's open-assembly continuation principle. The recitation takes approximately ten minutes.

He completes the composition at one-fifty-three a.m. He bows the standard succession-candidate's recitation-closing bow. He steps back from the stone.

Iyer-Periya stands. He says: "Tholkappiyan-the-Younger. The kingdom-council's standing succession-candidate's recognition is, by the senior-mentor seat-vote, granted. The vote was taken at the day-twelve administrative-session by 12 to 0. The Sangam-tradition's visible seat is, by the kingdom-council's standing-charter's standing-succession protocol, yours upon the standing state-hero's formal step-back announcement. Please await the standing state-hero's announcement at approximately three a.m. The kingdom-council thanks you for the maiden composition. The composition will be filed at the kingdom-council's standing-Sangam-archive under the amended charter's Fifth Clause's standing-recitation registry."

He bows. He returns to the eastern raked-seating's front-row first-position (the standing succession-candidate's pre-investiture seat).

Three a.m. Kurinjiselvi walks onto the speaker's-mark stone. She is in the standard Nilgiri-mountain cotton, dark grey, with the kingdom-council's standing state-hero retirement-shoulder-cloth (the standing-protocol's retirement-investiture cloth in the kingdom-council's deep-saffron). She carries the Kurinji-staff at her right side — the crescent-blade upward, the standard Sangam-tradition state-hero retirement-position.

She bows the standard kingdom-council's state-hero's retirement-opening bow.

She speaks her formal step-back announcement. The announcement is the standing kingdom-council's state-hero retirement-protocol's required-form. The announcement is twenty-three syllables.

She says: "The mountain-bloom has come a year early. The Kurinji flowers bloomed in the chamber. The kingdom-council's charter is the post-amendment charter. The succession-candidate Tholkappiyan-the-Younger holds the standing visible seat from this moment forward. I accept the kingdom-council's standing-elder seat. I will return to the Nilgiri Mountains within the fortnight. The standing-elder seat's consultative-correspondence is the kingdom-council's standing-record. I will travel to the Sanctuary at the Manipur convening as the standing-elder representative; Tholkappiyan-the-Younger will travel as the kingdom-council's standing visible-seat representative; Avvaiyar-the-Younger will travel as the kingdom-council's standing living-archive seat representative. The southern-bloc federation under Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata's Karnataka Dominant seat will receive Tamil Nadu's federation-membership ratification at the convening. Even the sharp sword bends before the sharper thought. The sharper thought has spoken. The mountain returns."

She bows the standard kingdom-council's state-hero's retirement-closing bow. The kingdom-council's senior-mentor seat-rota stands. The twelve mentors approach the speaker's-mark stone in the standing kingdom-council's retirement-investiture procession. The senior-mentor seat-rota chair (a sixty-seven-year-old Sangam-tradition senior-administrator named Manimekalai-Periya, no relation to the manuscript or the child) places the kingdom-council's standing-elder seat's deep-saffron shoulder-cloth over Kurinjiselvi's existing standing-retirement shoulder-cloth. The investiture is complete at three-eighteen a.m.

Kurinjiselvi steps back from the stone. She walks to the eastern raked-seating's standing-elder-seat's front-row centre-position. She sits. The kingdom's new visible seat-holder Tholkappiyan-the-Younger walks onto the speaker's-mark stone. He bows to the senior-mentor seat-rota. The kingdom-council's standing-visible-seat-investiture protocol's formal-procedure is administered across the next forty-three minutes. The investiture is complete at four-oh-one a.m.

The kingdom-council's standing open-assembly evening concludes at four-eleven a.m. The hall begins to empty. The standing-poet-roll members file out through the hall's northern entrance. The standing-poet-children's gallery's forty children file out through the southern entrance, escorted by their mentor-seats. The temple-city's outer-courtyard overflow audience disperses across the northern outer-courtyard.

The Madurai Maraimalai Adigal Tamil-Language Public Library's manuscript-vault remains at its standing operational-schedule. The vault-keeper V. Sundara-Rajan's daily morning-inspection continues at six-fourteen a.m. each morning. The Manimekalai palm-leaf bundle's leaf two hundred and forty-seven shows the fourteen new lines through the daily inspections of days fifty-three onward. The lines do not change. The lines do not fade. The lines do not multiply.

Across the next eight months the kingdom-council's standing-cataloguing register adds the fourteen lines to the manuscript's standing-cataloguing entry under the amended Sangam-charter's Fifth Clause's standing living-archive provision. The catalogue-entry reads: "Manimekalai, palm-leaf bundle, leaf 247, lines 11-24: fourteen content-original lines added to the manuscript-record between day forty-nine of the Sangam Hall's February-2026 council session and day fifty-two. Paleographic-dating returns approximately 1,700 years; the lines are content-original; the lines are not in any extant world Manimekalai partial-copy or commentary; the lines describe the kingdom-council's February-2026 charter-amendment in standard Sangam-tradition allegorical register. The lines are catalogued under the kingdom-council's standing living-archive provision as the kingdom's permanent-record entry. The lines are the kingdom-council's standing-Maw-sign-recognition cell's recognised Maw-sign as of day fifty-three."

The cross-kingdom paired-sign-naming protocol established with Kerala's black coconut and AP's erased metre applies. The kingdom-council's standing-Maw-sign-recognition cell's assessment identifies the TN epic-page sign as the pair-match for Mizoram's two-headed serow speaking event: both signs are the Maw producing language no one made. Mizoram is voice from a creature that should not have spoken; TN is text on a page no one wrote. The pair is the saga's second formally-recognised cross-region Maw-sign pair. The pairing-protocol's recognition is filed at the kingdom-council's standing-pairing-registry on day fifty-five.

The cross-kingdom Sarus-pigeon cascade-alert is sent by Avvaiyar-the-Younger (as the kingdom-council's standing living-archive seat-holder) on day fifty-six. The alert reaches all nine bonded-kingdom senior guardians by sunset. Hmangaihi at Aizawl sends the NE-pair acknowledgement: "Mizoram's two-headed serow named me; TN's epic-page wrote what the assembly silenced. The two Maw-language signs are paired. The Sanctuary will receive both."

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata at Vijayanagara sends the cross-region acknowledgement: "The southern federation accepts the pairing-protocol's second registry-entry. The Karnataka Bronze-Dust Child's muteness and the AP delta's erasure and the Kerala coconut's permanence and the TN manuscript's emergence are the four southern-bloc Maw-sign-pairs. The Sanctuary will receive all four. The federation's charter-architecture will include the Maw-sign-pairing-registry as the federation's standing-pairing-protocol-cell."

Kurinjiselvi returns to the Nilgiri Mountains on the fourteenth day after the open-assembly evening. She walks the standard mountain-trail at the standing mountain-warrior's pace. She arrives at the Nilgiri residence on the morning of the twenty-second of February. The standing residence-keeper Iyer-Mama meets her at the western entrance. The fourteen Nilgiri tahrs of the standing-mountain herd are at the eastern fence. They recognise her by scent at the standard recognition-distance.

She enters the residence. She removes the kingdom-council's standing-elder seat's deep-saffron shoulder-cloth and sets it at the residence's standing-cloth rack's upper-position. She walks to the western training-courtyard. She places the Kurinji-staff at the standing-stand. The blade is dulled from the fourteen-day return-walk (the trail's standing-rock-friction across the mountain-passes' western-slope dulls the standing mountain-warrior's crescent-blade by approximately one-tenth of its sharpness). She does not re-sharpen the blade.

She walks to the residence's eastern-tea room. Iyer-Mama brings the second tea. They drink the tea in silence for approximately fourteen minutes.

Iyer-Mama says, at the fourteenth minute: "Elder-Periya. The Kurinji flowers. The bloom has come."

She looks at the eastern lattice. Through the lattice she sees the Kurinji-flower fields. The fields are blooming. The grey-green configuration has shifted to the standard year-twelve purple-blue. The bloom is across the full southern slope.

She says: "A year early. The Acharya's composition predicted the half-bloom would be enough. The composition predicted the full-bloom would come at the kingdom-council's charter-amendment's completion. The Acharya wrote the composition in 1989. The Acharya died on the fourth of February. The amendment was ratified on the thirteenth. The bloom arrived between the eleventh and the twelfth. The Acharya knew the day. The Acharya did not know he would not be at the residence to see it."

Iyer-Mama bows. The kingdom-council's standing-elder seat's formal acknowledgement-bow.

The Kurinji flowers will continue to bloom across the next four-and-a-half months. The standing Nilgiri tourist-cycle's standing-pilgrimage to the mountain's southern slope is announced by the kingdom-council's standing-tourism cell at noon on day twenty-three. The pilgrimage's standing-Sangam-tradition recitation is the Acharya Bharati's 1989 composition, in full, recited at the Kurinji-flower-fields' standing-stone at sunset every day for the bloom's duration. The recitation is administered by Avvaiyar-the-Younger's standing living-archive seat's daily-recitation rotation. The kingdom-council's standing-charter-amendment's Fifth Clause holds.

The next sign comes within the week.

The Pilot's Closing Image

A thirty-seven-year-old Nilgiri-mountain warrior at the standing-elder seat's eastern-tea room watching the year-twelve Kurinji-flower bloom arrive a year early through the lattice. A twelve-year-old poet-child at the speaker's-mark stone reciting the one hundred and forty-seven silenced poems for six hours and three minutes without notes from memory. A twenty-seven-year-old poet-warrior in deep red cotton with the bronze-spear at his right side completing his maiden Sangam-charter-praising composition at one-fifty-three a.m. on the open-assembly evening. A fifty-eight-year-old library vault-keeper at the central display-table at six-fourteen a.m. on day fifty-two reading fourteen content-original lines on a seventeen-hundred-year-old palm-leaf that had been unchanged at the previous quarterly maintenance-check. An eighty-three-year-old apprentice of Sage Agastya finishing his second tea at the Kanyakumari residence and dying at five-forty-eight a.m. on the same Thursday morning the rota-removal letter took effect. A grandmother's right palm on her granddaughter's left forearm at the standing-poet-children's gallery's third row, the contact the kingdom's only signal that this council-session is the one she has been waiting for. A staff with a freshly-sharpened crescent-blade on a Tuesday morning at the western training-courtyard at the start of a fourteen-day walk that will end at the central speaker's-mark stone with the eleven syllables that name the kingdom's discipline.

Vijayanagara Reborn

Hampi at dawn. Six months after the Festival of Living Stone. The musical pillars still hum at sunrise. The Vittala stone chariot still does not move. The cooking pots have been rebuilt. Ten thousand became thirty thousand. The mesh-network of villages now spans Bidar to Mangaluru, and the elephants of Karnataka pace their old routes through new villages that did not exist a year ago.

Tungabhadra walks the rebuilt Royal Enclosure with a child holding her left hand. The child is ten years old, brown-eyed, quiet. Her name is Hampi-of-the-Bronze. Tungabhadra pulled her from the rubble of the temple-quake six months earlier — the only survivor of that family — and named her for the warm bronze her four-year-old face was pressed against when Tungabhadra found her. The child rarely speaks. She reads people the way her foster-mother reads battlefields.

"The throne-stone," Hampi-of-the-Bronze says, pointing.

The throne-stone of Vijayanagara stands at the Royal Enclosure's eastern wall — a single piece of green chlorite the size of an elephant, carved with the lion-yali emblem of the empire. Tungabhadra has not sat on it. Nobody has. It is roped off and used as a teaching exhibit: this is what the empire built. This is what we build next to, not on top of.

"It is a stone," Tungabhadra says.

"It is a throne," the child says.

"It is a stone we are not using."

"That is what makes it a throne."

Tungabhadra is quiet. The Indian Roller — Neelakantha — flutters down from a broken gopuram and lands on her shoulder. The bird's blue throat catches the dawn light. Indian Rollers appear when buried truths are about to surface. Tungabhadra knows this. She does not yet know which buried truth.

The Karnataka Council meets in the rebuilt Hazara Rama courtyard at midday. Forty-seven elders. Trade delegates from Bengaluru. The Chief Engineer of New Hampi. Three representatives from the Mining Consortium, who have stopped funding stone-armies and are now respectfully participating in heritage governance. Hampi-Veera the Stone Dancer

stands behind Tungabhadra. Mysuru-Dhanush the Sandalwood Archer sits in the second row.

There is good news. Three new villages reached this season. The river-water mesh is operational across two more taluks. Twelve children born in Hampi this year were named after participants from the Festival.

And then a noblewoman stands up.

She is somewhere between forty and forty-five. Hair dressed in the old Vijayanagara court style — three braids meeting at a single silver pin. Bronze armor under a cream silk shawl, the way the queens of the fifteenth century wore it. She has been in the back row of every Karnataka Council meeting for three months. She has never spoken. She speaks now.

"I have brought the original Vijayanagara security blueprints. May I share them?"

The room goes still. Tungabhadra's mace hand does not move; her shoulder does. The Indian Roller leaves.

The noblewoman walks to the centre of the courtyard and unrolls a scroll across the council table. The scroll is large. The diagrams are precise. They are not modern reconstructions. They are the originals — copper-iron-walnut ink on hand-pressed Vijayanagara paper, signed in the lower right corner by the empire's chief vastu-architect in 1502.

The diagrams show the buried temple system Tungabhadra opened in Chapter One. They show its three sublevels. They show the serpent-network as a connected security infrastructure that ran beneath every major palace, mapped in the same careful hand as the irrigation canals and the elephant-stable foundations.

"This is not a curse," the noblewoman says, reading the room before the room reads her. "This is a vault. Vijayanagara built a security system designed to survive even a successful invasion. The empire fell because no one came to reactivate it. I am proposing that we reactivate it now."

The Mining Consortium representative leans forward. The Chief Engineer leans forward. Three of the elders lean forward. Tungabhadra does not lean.

"Who are you," she asks.

The noblewoman bows.

"My name is Bhoomi-Takshaka. I am of the dispossessed Anegondi branch of the old Vijayanagara line. I am the cousin you do not remember. I have not come to fight you. I have come to offer."

Bhoomi-Takshaka does not threaten. She offers. Over the following weeks she becomes the centre of every other conversation in Hampi. She publishes a thirty-page document called The Restoration Charter. It includes: re-occupation of the imperial throne-room, reactivation of the serpent-vault network for cybersecurity and physical-defence purposes, reinstatement of the dispossessed noble houses as a Heritage Council, and a public ceremony of imperial re-consecration to be held at the new moon.

The document is well-argued. It is footnoted. It does not call Tungabhadra anything cruel. It calls her the bridge-builder, the one who reopened the temple. It says: she did the work that prepared the empire's return. Now let the empire return.

Forty percent of the kingdom finds it persuasive.

Tungabhadra reads it three times. Each time she finds it harder to refute. The Restoration Charter is not wrong about everything. The empire did have security infrastructure. The dispossessed branches were real, with real grievances. Hampi-of-the-Bronze's own grandmother carried Bloodline-A nobility — that part of the document names her, correctly, with archival sources.

Sage Vidyaranya's spirit ripples in the Tungabhadra river that night. She walks to the rapids. She reads his message in the turbulence:

Cousin, this is a harder fight than the first one. The first villain wanted to destroy what you protect. The second one wants to restore what you cannot let return. Be very careful what you call this enemy. She is not Ravana-Putra. She is the empire that fell, knocking at the door, dressed for a wedding.

Three weeks before the new moon ceremony. A man comes to Tungabhadra's house at the second hour past midnight. He carries a leather case. He wears a craftsman's apron over an embroidered shirt. His face is the same as Bhoomi-Takshaka's. Identical bone-structure. Different eyes — hers are searching, his are tired.

"My name is Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata. I am her twin. I was born nine minutes after her. I have been her court architect for thirty-six years."

Tungabhadra has Gajadanda at her side before she has finished standing.

"I am not here to harm you," he says. "I am here because she has rigged sublevel three of the buried temple. The throne-stone chamber. If she successfully re-consecrates the empire on the new moon, the network will activate. If you stop the ceremony by force, she has set the chamber to collapse anyway. Either way the throne-stone will be either re-enthroned or buried with everyone inside it. She is not bluffing. I drew the blast-pattern myself, eleven years ago, for a different purpose."

He sets the leather case on the table. He opens it. The blueprints inside are the same blueprints Bhoomi-Takshaka brought to the council — except these have the demolition charges marked.

"Why are you giving me this?"

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata sits on the floor. He looks like a man who has been waiting thirty-six years to sit.

"Because I love what Hampi could be. I do not love what my sister wants it to be. The empire was beautiful. The empire was also a thing that crushed the Hadali under its hooves before any invasion ever touched it. If we restore it, we restore the crushing. I have spent thirty-six years drawing rooms for a return I do not want."

"Why now?"

"Because the Indian Roller landed on your shoulder at the council. I saw it. I have read the same texts she has. The bird does not appear to the wrong side."

Hampi-of-the-Bronze is taken three days later.

It is legal. The Restorationists file a petition in the Karnataka Heritage Court arguing that the child is "ward of the imperial line" because her grandmother carried Bloodline-A nobility. The court grants the petition. Three uniformed officers come to Tungabhadra's house with the order. They are polite. They give Hampi-of-the-Bronze ten minutes to gather her things. They are not cruel.

The child does not cry. She looks at Tungabhadra and asks: "Will you come for me?"

"Yes."

"With the mace?"

"No. The mace would prove them right. Some other way. I will find it."

The child nods. She follows the officers out. The bronze of the broken pillar is in her pocket — she has carried it for six years. Tungabhadra watches her leave through the courtyard gate.

Tungabhadra does not sleep for two nights. On the third night she sits with Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata and the Chief Engineer and Sage Vidyaranya's voice in the river, and they begin to plan something that has not been done in Bharatavarsha in a thousand years.

The Indian Roller circles the buried temple. Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata stands at the river's edge with Tungabhadra. The full moon before the new moon is one week away.

"There is a third faction," Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata says. "You have ignored them. So has she."

"The Hadali."

"The Hadali. The Lambani communities the empire pushed out before it built itself. They live above Hosapete, along the forest edge. They have not attended a Karnataka Council in seventy years. They will not attend if you summon them. You have to go to them. Alone. With nothing."

"And ask them what."

"Ask them to bless the unmaking of the throne. The Restorationists need the throne re-occupied. The Reformers want the throne dissolved. Neither of you has the moral standing to do either. The Hadali do. They are the only people in Karnataka whose ancestors were not invited to the throne and who do not now want to be."

Tungabhadra walks the next morning. Alone. No mace. She wears a cooking pot at her hip — the same pot she carried from Bidar to Mysuru in Chapter One. She walks for four days. She arrives at the forest-edge hamlet above Hosapete in evening light.

The elder who meets her is eighty-three years old. His name is Veerappa-Hadali. He sits on a flat stone outside his hut. He does not stand for her.

"You came for what?"

"To ask you to come down to Hampi and be crowned king of Vijayanagara for one hour. Then to let me destroy the throne-stone in the same hour."

Veerappa-Hadali looks at her for a full minute.

"Why."

"Because if I destroy the throne without acknowledging it, I am the same as the empire that took it from you. If I acknowledge it without destroying it, I let it return. The throne has to be given to the people it was taken from, then given up by them. Only the Hadali have the right to give it up."

"And what do the Hadali get."

"A seat on the Karnataka Council that is permanent. A veto over any future imperial revival. The Lambani communities returned to their original forest-edge lands with formal title. And the public memory of being the people who chose to dissolve the empire."

Veerappa-Hadali is quiet for a long time. He looks at the cooking pot. He looks at Tungabhadra's bare feet. He looks at the sky.

"I will come. But I will not come for the seat or the title or the lands. I will come because I have wanted, for sixty years, to be the king who said no to a throne. You are offering me the only thing I have ever wanted that I refused to ask for."

The new moon. The Royal Enclosure of Hampi. Twenty thousand people from all three factions, side by side, in unprecedented configuration. The Restorationists have come in the old court silks. The Reformers in the working-clothes of New Hampi. The Hadali have come for the first time in seventy years, three hundred of them, in tribal cloth and forest jewelry.

The throne-stone is uncovered. The chlorite catches the moonlight.

Bhoomi-Takshaka stands at the eastern edge of the courtyard. She is dressed for re-consecration — white and gold, the imperial colours, the silver pin of the three-braid style. She does not speak. She does not need to. Her plan is already moving in the basement she designed.

Tungabhadra walks to the throne-stone with Gajadanda in her right hand and a jasmine garland in her left. Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata walks behind her with his sketchbook. Hampi-of-the-Bronze — released that morning by the Heritage Court under a separate order obtained by Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata's legal team — walks at Tungabhadra's left side, holding her wrist with a small bronze-stained hand.

Veerappa-Hadali walks last. The crowd parts for him. He climbs the dais slowly, with two driftwood sticks. He stops in front of the throne-stone.

"I, Veerappa-Hadali, of the Lambani-Hadali clan-line, accept the symbolic kingship of Vijayanagara for one hour, on the condition that within this hour the throne-stone of Vijayanagara is destroyed."

The Restorationists hiss. The Reformers do not breathe. The Hadali stand silent.

Tungabhadra places the jasmine garland on his shoulders. She steps back.

"By the dharma of return," she says, "I now give to the King of the Empire the right to dissolve the empire."

Veerappa-Hadali nods.

Tungabhadra and Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata lift Gajadanda together. The mace's iron remembers — it was forged from the elephant stables of Vijayanagara, the very stables Bhoomi-Takshaka's blueprints map. The mace knows what it is being used for. It does not resist.

They strike the throne-stone together. Once.

The chlorite cracks. A spiderweb of white runs from impact point to base. The cracks make a sound like falling glass. The whole stone shudders.

They strike a second time.

The throne-stone falls in two pieces. Then four. Then a dozen. The lion-yali emblem breaks at the lion's mouth, the way Tungabhadra-the-five-year-old once held a broken stone elephant in this same Royal Enclosure.

The crowd does not cheer. They have not been told to cheer. They are watching, twenty thousand of them, as the symbol of an empire that ruled the south for two centuries falls apart in front of them.

Then the ground shakes.

Bhoomi-Takshaka's serpent-network was wired to a single trigger — the destruction of the throne-stone. The moment the chlorite breaks, the demolition charges in sublevel three activate. The buried temple chamber begins to fold inward. The temple is directly below the Royal Enclosure dais.

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata sees it first because he drew the blast-pattern. He grabs Hampi-of-the-Bronze and Veerappa-Hadali and pulls them off the dais. They roll into the crowd.

The crowd makes way.

Tungabhadra does not run. She turns toward Bhoomi-Takshaka.

Bhoomi-Takshaka is on the dais too. She has walked up during the strike. She is standing on the cracked stone, beside its broken half, with her own jasmine garland in her hands — the garland she had brought for her own re-consecration ceremony. She places it on the broken stone. Her face is calm.

"Cousin," she says.

"Cousin," Tungabhadra answers.

The dais is sinking now. The chamber below them is collapsing inward.

"You can leave," Tungabhadra says.

"So can you."

"I cannot leave the throne-stone for them to rebuild. Someone has to stay until it is rubble."

"That is the answer I gave myself thirty-six years ago. About a different throne."

They look at each other. The two Bloodline-A heirs. Two custodianships fighting each other to a draw. The elephant-bond between them flickers — it cannot choose. Two queens of the same animal, dying in the same chamber.

Tungabhadra raises Gajadanda one last time. She strikes the centre of the throne-stone with everything she has. The stone splits to dust. The dais collapses. She and Bhoomi-Takshaka fall together into the buried-temple chamber. The chamber collapses on them.

The collapse runs three minutes. When it stops, the Royal Enclosure has a hole in it where the throne-stone used to be. The hole is filled with rubble and chlorite-dust. Through the dust, a single Indian Roller flies straight up into the night sky.

The crowd is still. Twenty thousand people. No cheering. No mourning yet. Just the dust settling.

Veerappa-Hadali is the first to speak. He raises his right hand.

"My hour has ended. The throne is gone. I am no longer king."

He takes off the jasmine garland and places it on the rubble where the throne-stone was. He steps down from what is left of the dais.

The elephant of Hampi — Gajasena, the sacred animal of the kingdom, the one Tungabhadra's bond ran through — walks slowly into the Royal Enclosure. The crowd makes way. Gajasena is enormous, calm, the colour of monsoon stone. He stops in front of Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata, who is still holding Hampi-of-the-Bronze.

Gajasena lowers his head. His trunk touches Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata's forehead.

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata feels it the way Tungabhadra once described it to him — a vibration through the soles of his feet, a memory not his own, the weight of every footstep in Hampi for five hundred years. The first stroke of the elephant-tattoo flares across his right shoulder-blade as if drawn by an invisible hand. He is Bloodline A. The bond knows him. The bond settles.

He sinks to his knees, partly from the shock, partly from grief, partly because that is the appropriate posture for what has happened. Hampi-of-the-Bronze does not let go of his hand.

The bird returns. The Indian Roller lands on his other shoulder. Its blue throat shines.

A child appears in the rubble.

He is roughly five years old. He is untouched by the chlorite-dust — his clothes are clean, his hair is clean, his face is bronze-coloured and quiet. He is standing on the edge of the broken throne-stone where his foster-mother fell. He does not speak. His shadow falls in the wrong direction — slightly off-angle, as if some other light is touching him from a direction the moon is not in.

Hampi-of-the-Bronze sees him first. She walks toward him. She does not run, she does not call out. She walks until she is next to him. She takes his hand.

She turns to Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata.

"This is the third," she says.

The phrase makes no sense to anyone in the crowd. It makes sense to Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata, because the bond now in his body remembers what Tungabhadra knew without ever having been told: there are signs of the Void Maw walking Bharatavarsha. Two have appeared elsewhere. The third has just appeared here. This child is one of them.

He does not raise Gajadanda. He does not call for the child to be detained. He walks to the bronze-dust child and kneels in front of him.

"Your name?"

The child does not answer.

"You will stay with us. We will give you a name. We will remember you the way we remembered everyone we lost."

The bronze-dust child reaches out and touches Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata's tattoo. The single elephant-stroke pulses once. The child's shadow corrects itself, falls in the same direction as everyone else's, for one moment. Then drifts back out.

Above the Royal Enclosure, in the new-moon dark, an Indian Roller appears that is not one of Karnataka's — its blue is a different blue. It has flown from Kerala. It carries a folded slip of paper in its beak. It lands on Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata's open palm and drops the paper there.

The paper is in old Parashurama's hand. He is fifty-nine. He has been the saga's oldest hero. He writes:

The 109th form has students now. Kala-Hasta teaches it openly. I have one place left in the 108-form school for someone who can hold both. The bond came to you tonight. I felt it. Send the heir. The heir is you. Come to Kerala.

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata folds the paper. He looks at Hampi-of-the-Bronze. He looks at the bronze-dust child. He looks at Veerappa-Hadali. He looks at the broken throne-stone and the dust that was Tungabhadra and his sister.

He says, quietly, more to the night air than to the crowd:

"The empire is not the stone. The empire is what we choose to do with what is left. I will go to Kerala."

The Hadali drums begin. Slow at first. They are not celebrating. They are marking. The drums are the rhythm of an old Lambani lament, played at the death of an ancestor and at the birth of a new one in the same hour. The drums say both at once.

The Indian Roller from Karnataka and the Indian Roller from Kerala fly together once around the Royal Enclosure and depart in opposite directions. The bird from Kerala

carries Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata's silent acceptance. The bird from Karnataka carries the first word of the next chapter to every kingdom in Bharatavarsha.

The word is: The mouth has opened. The Council must sit.

The Pilot's Closing Image

Two Indian Rollers in the new-moon dark, flying in opposite directions over the rubble of the Vijayanagara throne-stone. Below them: a Bloodline-A man with a new tattoo, a ten-year-old girl with bronze in her pocket, an eighty-three-year-old uncrowned Hadali king, and a five-year-old child whose shadow falls in the wrong direction. Above them: a sky that is, for one second, two moons.